Indira Gandhi National Open University
School of Journalism and New Media Studies

BNM-021
Introduction to Journalism and Digital Media

Block

4

CONTEMPORARY ISSUES OF DIGITAL MEDIA

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In **Block 4, Contemporary Issues of Digital Media**, we will delve into crucial topics like the intersection of the Internet and Marginalisation, understanding the Conceptual Framework of Digital Inequality, exploring Global Communication Policies, and examining the intricate landscape of Internet Governance. This Block contains four Units that delve into the digital landscape's crucial aspects. Unit 15 explores the Internet's impact on Marginalisation. Unit 16 uncovers the Conceptual Framework of Digital Inequality. Unit 17 examines Global Communication Policies. Unit 18 delves into the complex realm of Internet Governance, addressing regulations and control in the digital world.

Unit 15, Internet and Marginalisation, uncovers the Definitions and Dimensions of Marginalisation, delving into Theoretical Interpretations such as the Marxist Approach and Crenshaw's Approach. Examine the dichotomy of the Internet as a Boon or Bane and explore its impact on Marginality through a Pessimistic View of Digital Marginalisation, including the Indian Context and Representation of Marginalised Sections. Embrace the Functional Aspects of the Internet with an Optimistic View, understanding Agency, Identity, Power Relationships, and Digital Participation while exploring relevant Indian Contexts.

This **Unit 16, Conceptual Framework of Digital Inequality,** explores Conceptual Development, shifting from Divide to Inequality and uncovering Dimensions of Digital Inequality. Examine its impact on Contemporary Society, Information Society, and the Network Society. Embrace the Technological Approach through Diffusion of Innovation, UTAUT, and Resources and Appropriation Theory. Understand Conceptual Dimensions from a Sociological Perspective with Bourdieusian and Weberian Approaches. Discover the significance of Digital Capital, Digital Inclusion-Exclusion, and Participation, as well as explore New Forms of Digital Inequality in the evolving digital landscape.

Unit 17, Global Media Policies, discover the captivating journey through A Brief History and Evolutionary Concerns in Development of Global Communication Policies. Explore Broad Classifications based on Content-Carriage and Functional Dimensions. Uncover the Global Media Policy Landscape, delving into Power Dynamics, Key Organizations, and Recent Influences. Evaluate Global Media Policies with Research Organizations and Performance Indexes, identifying countries with strong commitments and those facing challenges. Embrace the intriguing realm of Challenges and Opportunities in Global Media Policies.

Unit 18, Internet Governance, explores the Emergence of the Internet, Informal Governance, and the Formation of ICANN while uncovering the Role of the United States of America. Understand Globalisation, the World Summit on the Information Society, and the Montevideo Statement's impact on the IANA Transition. Discover the Importance of Internet Governance for a Stable and Secure Internet, an open and innovative global platform, User Rights and Privacy, and Global Collaboration. Dive into Key Organisations in Internet Governance, Landmark Decisions, Internet Governance in India, Challenges, Opportunities, Civic Movements, and the Ranking of Countries in Internet Governance.

This Block delves into core aspects of global internet governance, including regulation, security issues, and equitable distribution of its benefits across society. By exploring this module, you will gain a comprehensive understanding of these broader concepts and their impact on the digital revolution's inclusivity and prosperity for all.

UNIT 15 INTERNET AND MARGINALISATION

Structure

15.0 INTRODUCTION

The term "marginalisation" comes from the word "margin," which refers to something on the edge. The multifaceted concept of marginalisation contains many meanings to describe the lived experience of millions worldwide who lack political, economic, and social resources. People on the margins of society have limited control over their lives and opportunities. In addition to marginalisation at the national and global levels, classes and communities can also be marginalised locally by the prevailing social order.

The Internet greatly impacts the lives of marginalised people because it provides them with information, resources, opportunities, and communication platforms; however, digital inequality is a significant challenge here. The fact that not all underprivileged groups enjoy equal internet access and skills is an alarming indicator of the persistence of digital inequities. Cost, infrastructure, digital literacy, and language can all limit internet access and prevent marginalised communities from obtaining full benefits.

This unit concentrates on the opportunities and challenges presented by the Internet in the context of the marginalisation of Scheduled Castes (Dalits), Scheduled Tribes (Adivasis), Other Backward Classes (OBCs), religious minorities (Muslims et al., and others), women, the LGBTQ+ community, persons with disabilities, etc. It elaborates on the techno-optimistic and techno-pessimistic views of marginalisation and creates an in-depth understanding of the topic.

15.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit, you will be able to:

- understand the concept of marginalisation and its causes and dimensions;
- explore the role of the Internet in the lives of marginalised individuals and communities;
- discuss the socio-centric and techno-centric accounts of marginalisation; and
- understand the usage of the Internet by the marginalised individual or community and for the marginalised individual or community.

15.2 CONCEPTUAL UNDERSTANDING OF MARGINALISATION

We can observe marginalisation through the interconnectedness of the exclusion and inclusion of an individual or a specific social group. Social exclusion and marginalisation are related terms, as they are often discussed in the context of one another. The unequal distribution of resources, opportunities, and authority in society leads to social exclusion. Individuals or communities experience social exclusion when they cannot fully participate in or access the benefits of mainstream society. Therefore, to be socially excluded is to be on the fringes of society. The dominant or privileged groups maintain and reinforce social inequality by using their power to oppress the less powerful or marginalised groups. In society, marginalisation manifests in a variety of ways, including for those who are disenfranchised due to poverty and location, race and ethnicity, sexual orientation, disability and/or illness, religion, and personal circumstances, such as the descendants of migrants and refugees (Mowat, 2015). Marginalised Individuals or groups may encounter systematic barriers that prohibit them from accessing resources, opportunities, and rights that others in society have. They may face discrimination, prejudice, stigma, and inequitable treatment.

15.2.1 Definition of Marginalisation

The process by which an individual or group is driven to the fringes or periphery of society, often resulting in their exclusion or limited participation in mainstream activities and decision-making processes, is referred to as "marginalisation". The Oxford Learner's Dictionary defines marginalisation as "the process or result of making somebody feel as if they are not important and cannot influence decisions or events; the fact of putting somebody in a position in which they have no power". According to Mowat (2015), "To be marginalised is to have a sense that one does not belong and, in so doing, to feel that one is neither a valued member of a community nor able to make a valuable contribution within that community nor able to access the range of services and/or opportunities open to others". Marginality has a tremendous impact on the development of human beings and society at large. Marginalisation can manifest in different forms, including poverty, limited educational and employment prospects, a lack of political representation, and restricted access to healthcare and other essential services.

15.2.2 Dimensions of Marginalization

Exclusion from promoting individual autonomy through economic, social, or political means may have unintended consequences. According to Messiou (2012), marginalisation can manifest in different forms. These dimensions, at various levels, depend on the political economy of a country. Although no one rule can explain the complex dynamics of marginalisation, it is observed through the lens of strategic actions in terms of social, economic, and political means of achieving life chances.

Social Marginalisation

Social marginalisation is being outside the mainstream of productive and/or social reproductive activity (Leonard, 1984). Socially marginalised individuals have limited access to social opportunities. They may become stigmatised and are frequently subjected to negative public attitudes. Many circumstances can give rise to the feeling of being on the social margins, for example, individuals such as differently abled people or those born into marginal communities (for example, lower castes in India). This kind of marginality is typically lifelong and greatly determines their lived experience.

Economic Marginalisation

Economic marginalisation is marginalisation related to economic structures. It is the consequence of disparities in wealth accumulation or employment opportunities. It sometimes has an economic origin; however, it may have non-economic origins, for example, in discrimination by gender, caste, or ethnicity.

Political Marginalisation

Political marginalisation prevents individuals or groups from participating in democratic decision-making, consequently forfeiting their entitlement to all social, economic, and political benefits. For example, women's political involvement in developing nations is strongly associated with political marginalisation. Sections such as ethnic minorities and migrants all experience this type of marginalisation to varying degrees.

15.3 THEORETICAL INTERPRETATION

Class, ideology, social consciousness, and human activity are helpful analytical tools in particular social, cultural, economic, and political contexts, causing marginalisation across digital spheres. Theories provide diverse perspectives on the tangents of internet-driven marginalisation. They emphasise the significance of the power dynamics of identity, social inequalities, and complex intersecting processes of marginalisation. By examining Marxists and Crenshaw's approach, researchers and educators can develop strategies for challenging and addressing the relationship between the Internet and marginalisation and the mechanisms underlying digital marginalisation.

15.3.1 The Marxist Approach

The Marxist analysis sheds insight into the conditions and experiences of those marginalised in capitalist society, especially in the digital sphere. Marx's views on marginalised communities can be comprehended in his capitalism and class conflict concept. Marx examined society through the lens of economic relationships and unequal wealth and power distribution. It analyses the capital and power concentration within the digital economy. By analysing the concentration of digital capital and power, it is possible to comprehend how it moulds the digital landscape and exacerbates digital marginalisation by reinforcing class-based inequalities.

Marxists strongly emphasise the value of owning and managing the means of production. This comprises platforms, data, algorithms, and infrastructure in the context of digital technology. We can comprehend how power is concentrated in the hands of a few entities, such as IT corporations or platform owners, by looking at who owns and manages these digital resources. Marxists also highlight the prejudices and exclusionary behaviours ingrained in digital algorithms. The interests, values, and power dynamics of those who create and maintain algorithms are reflected in them rather than acting neutrally. This may result in unfair outcomes, including biased judgements, profiling, and the exclusion of marginalised groups.

15.3.2 Crenshaw's Approach

Crenshaw's intersectionality framework shows how important it is to recognise and deal with overlapping systems of power, the amplification of inequalities, and the need for inclusive and intersectional ways to access, reflect, and participate in digital spaces. The concept of intersectionality developed by Kimberlé Crenshaw emphasises that individuals may experience multiple forms of marginalisation due to the intersection of multiple social categories, such as race, gender, class, sexual orientation, and ability.

In the digital realm, individuals at the intersections of multiple marginalised identities may face compounded forms of discrimination and marginalisation. For example, a person who is both a member of a racial group and a woman may face different kinds of exclusion in the digital space because of how race and gender interact. Accessing digital resources, participating in online communities, and earning the benefits of digital advancements may become more difficult for individuals who intersect multiple marginalised identities. Intersectionality helps us understand how digital technologies can amplify existing inequalities.

15.4 INTERNET - BOON OR BANE

The Internet is a new medium with many facets comprising technical components and social structures, with the latter lending meaning and significance to the former. It is difficult to generalise the effects of the Internet on marginalised communities and individuals because there are so many facets to consider. The global reach and accessibility of the Internet can both foster greater equality and exacerbate existing disparities. Information, resources, and educational opportunities that may have been out of reach for marginalised groups are now available via the Internet. It can elevate marginalised perspectives and counter-hegemonic narratives and empower bottom-up movements for social change and justice.

Nevertheless, digital inequality is a barrier on an individual level and throughout the process. Digital inequality occurs when marginalised populations, such as those living in low-income areas or rural areas, cannot fully participate in the digital sphere because of restrictions on internet access. Furthermore, false narratives or stigmatising content may aim at marginalised communities, furthering the stereotypes and exclusion that already exist about them.

The role of the Internet in marginalisation can be observed through the lens of either cyber-pessimism or cyber-optimism. Cyber-pessimism has a more sceptical view of the Internet than cyber-optimism, which praises it as a free, interactive, democratising medium. Cyber-optimists argue that the rise of digital technology will lead to beneficial political, economic, and social shifts. They highlight the Internet's potential for democratisation, its capacity to link people worldwide, and the chances it provides for new forms of thought and action to emerge from the resulting connections. Cyberoptimists typically see technology as a driver of development, social inclusion, and expanded opportunity for everybody.

However, cyber-pessimism points to the effects of digital technologies more sceptically and fears the consequences of rapid digitalisation. Cyber-pessimists worry that people and communities may suffer due to the widespread use of these technologies. They voice about data breaches, surveillance, false information, the digital gap, cyberbullying, online harassment, and the consolidation of wealth and power in the hands of a few firms.

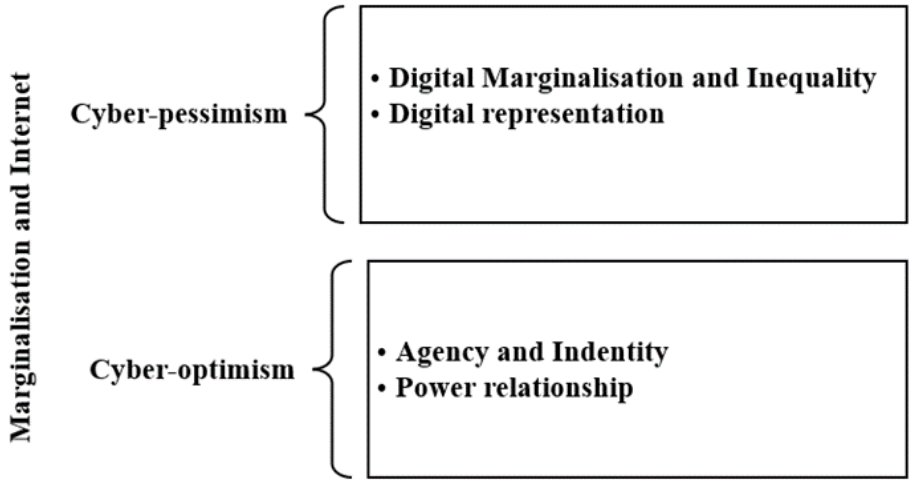

Fig.1. Cyber-pessimistic vs. cyber-optimistic views on the Internet

Source: Author's compilation

A wide range of user capabilities, such as computer literacy, technical skills, psychological aspects, and social elements, are required to use digital technology. Most developed nations have invested considerable resources at the governmental level to bridge the digital gap. The goal of these intervention programmes is frequently to ensure that all people have equal access to facilities and services. However, underlying issues with the excluded community's digital inclusion exist, such as a need for more demand-driven and contextualised interventions. Lack of content creation also contributes to digital marginalisation on an individual level.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. Explain the concept of "marginalisation".

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2. How can you use Crenshaw's intersectionality framework to understand marginalisation across internet platforms?

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3. What is cyber-optimism?

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4. Explain the Marxist approach to "internet and marginalisation".

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15.5 INTERNET AND MARGINALITY: PESSIMISTIC VIEW

Hoang et al. (2020) put forward a pessimistic viewpoint on digital technologies, stating that technology benefits advantaged groups more than those in need. In line with Hoang et al., marginalised populations are particularly susceptible to the adverse effects of digital development. For marginalised identities, a lack of participation in digital platforms and the use of digital media frequently results in further marginalisation.

Exclusion, invisibility, misrepresentation, and hate speech are all challenges that marginalised communities face, and these problems are becoming more prevalent in the digital sphere due to technological advancements. Recognising these problems can contribute to advancing digital inclusion by promoting diverse online representation, providing support, and mitigating harassment and discrimination online.

15.5.1 Digital Marginalisaton

People without access to diverse digital technologies and the Internet are often the focus of the idea of digital marginalisation. It refers to exclusion or limited participation in the digital sphere, encompassing various technological and online-based aspects. Due to barriers, specific individuals or communities cannot completely access and benefit from digital technologies and online platforms. Digital marginalisation can exacerbate existing social and economic disparities. Those who are already marginalised due to factors such as race, ethnicity, socioeconomic status, gender, or geographic location may experience exacerbated disadvantages in terms of educational opportunities, employment prospects, and social connections due to inadequate digital access and skills.

Digital marginalisation manifests itself in numerous ways, and the Matthew effect has been noticed in its emergence in numerous domains of society. Addressing digital marginalisation requires bridging the digital divide, promoting digital literacy, and providing skills training. Besides, top-down inclusivity by addressing biases in algorithms and content moderation and creating inclusive digital environments that respect and amplify marginalised voices might be necessary to improve the condition.

Digital marginalisation can occur for various reasons, discussed as follows:

- **Access and Infrastructure:** Inequality in access to technology and the Internet can result in digital marginalisation. The ability of members of marginalised communities to fully engage in online activities and make use of online opportunities and resources may be constrained by a lack of access to internet connections and devices.

- **Knowledge Gaps:** Although the Internet offers a wealth of knowledge, marginalised groups may have trouble accessing it because of linguistic obstacles, complex algorithms, or the predominance of particular viewpoints. This could exacerbate already-existing inequalities and limit their capacity to make accurate decisions.
- **Online harassment and discrimination:** Discrimination and online harassment may be more prevalent for marginalised people and groups, who may also experience higher rates of cyberbullying, hate speech, and harassment online. Online spaces can promote negative preconceptions, biases, and discriminatory attitudes, resulting in unfriendly situations that further marginalise and exclude particular communities.
- **Privacy and Security:** Privacy and security concerns can also contribute to digital marginalisation, particularly for vulnerable individuals. The fear of surveillance and data intrusions can inhibit online participation, especially among groups with fewer digital skills.
- **Representation:** The Internet can amplify power disparities and encourage marginalisation by promoting preconceptions and limiting representation. In digital representation, dominant narratives and powerful figures may have increased attention and influence, while some voices and opinions may be marginalised or underrepresented.
- **Algorithmic Bias:** The algorithms employed by social media platforms, search engines, and other online services can perpetuate discrimination and bias against marginalised communities. For instance, search engine results may reflect biased assumptions regarding race, gender, or other characteristics.

15.5.2 Digital Marginalisation: Indian Context

The impact of digital inequality on marginalised communities, especially those in rural or low-income areas, may cause them to encounter difficulties getting online, exacerbating already existing disparities. The digital divide between rural and urban inhabitants in India illustrates how the Internet may exacerbate social exclusion. Internet use is widespread in cities, but many rural areas still lack the most fundamental digital infrastructure, like consistent data connections. The digital gender divide in India is another prevalent case in point. Fewer women in India have access to and skills in using computers and the Internet.

Furthermore, linguistic limitations are a potential cause of digital exclusion. Although there are 22 recognised languages spoken in India, many resources on the web are written only in English or Hindi, which excludes millions of people. This can further contribute to the marginalisation of language minorities by limiting their access to online education, employment opportunities, and other digital resources. Because of the dominant languages and cultures, tribal populations face digital marginalisation in India. Cyberbullying and other forms of online bigotry amplify the effects of digital exclusion in India. When people are harassed online because of who they are or what they believe, it can make the Internet a hostile place where people are less likely to express themselves and are less likely to feel safe doing so. Inequalities and exclusion in society may become even more entrenched as a result.

15.5.3 Representation of Marginalised Sections

Representation is the process through which the media portrays and shows people, groups, and events, influencing how we think about and understand the world. Media representations are mediated depictions of social realities through media text that refers to any media content, including written and visual content. The digital media representation of marginalised communities often creates discrimination and stereotyping that reduces the self-esteem, effort, and performance of people from that specific community.

Our understanding and experience of the world around us are shaped by the images, stories, symbols, and language chosen for media portrayal and presented using framing and priming. It affects how we perceive social categories, such as gender, race, ethnicity, sexual orientation, age, disabilities, and socioeconomic class.

The idea of representation also draws attention to the power relationships that are prevalent in the production and distribution of media. Feenberg's (1991) critical theory of technology introduces the concept of 'technological rationality' to imply that the creation of technology is highly political and heavily directed by dominating groups, the elite. The prominent members of the Frankfurt School, including Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer, argued that elites use mass media and other cultural mechanisms to maintain the status quo at all levels of society. The Frankfurt School criticised the media for reinforcing the established social order through cultural imperialism. Mass media or digital media representation of any community or group follows the dominant pattern of social order, making the marginalised more marginal by cultivating societal norms. However, when we talk about digital media, representation can reinforce stereotypes, biases, and inequalities or challenge and subvert them. For example, women are frequently portrayed in various nuanced ways in digital media narratives. While some storylines reinforce preconceptions and objectify women, others offer diverse, empowering images that go against tradition. Female-led narrative, which presents women as powerful, autonomous, and complex characters with agency and a range of experiences, is becoming more popular.

15.6 FUNCTIONAL ASPECTS OF THE INTERNET: OPTIMISTIC VIEW

The Internet, which stands for "interconnected network," is a global network of computers and other devices that are all connected. This lets people talk to each other, share information, and use different online services. It is a massive set of systems that lets people worldwide meet and share information. The Internet is decentralised, which means no one person or group is in charge of it. Instead, it is made up of a network of networks that are linked through wired and wireless links and other technologies. The Internet offers various services and apps, such as email, social media platforms, search engines, online shopping, video streaming, cloud computing, and more. Parallelly, the digital media act as alternative forums for marginalised communities because the mainstream media is frequently accused of only promoting the dominant frame by omitting or misrepresenting the oppressed.

15.6.1 Agency and Identity

Marginalised individuals' perceptions of themselves and their actions in the world are influenced and shaped by the interconnected concepts of agency and identity. Individuals with the agency are motivated and assured to shape their identities to reflect their autonomy and uniqueness. Identity can also affect the agency. The beliefs, values, and social roles associated with a person's identity can influence their sense of agency by providing decision-making and behavioural frameworks and standards.

Agency: Gillespie (2010) says that agency is the practice of choice, which is when a socially situated person acts independently of an immediate situation, weighing and choosing between different ways to respond to social demands based on goals that may be driven by things that are not related to the immediate situation. The Internet can give marginalised individuals agency in several ways, as follows:

i) Through the Internet, disadvantaged people and groups can easily access previously unreachable or constrained information. They can learn about their rights, opportunities, and resources to advocate for their needs and make educated decisions.

ii) Marginalised people can express themselves and share their thoughts, experiences, and stories with a worldwide audience through various internet facilities, such as social media, blogs, and other digital platforms.

iii) The Internet enables marginalised people to interact with others who have similar experiences and identities.

iv) Marginalised people can work with allies, join larger movements, and bring about more significant change using online channels.

v) The Internet offers an economic opportunity, which leads to providing agency to people in need.

For example, women have received agency and opportunities for personal, social, and professional advancement. Digital technology provides entrepreneurship platforms, online markets, and freelance opportunities, enabling women to attain financial independence.

Identity Creation: Identity incorporates individual identity (unique characteristics that differentiate one individual from another) and social identity (affiliation with particular social groups based on shared characteristics such as culture, ethnicity, gender, or interests). The Internet provides a platform where marginalised individuals and communities can find visibility and representation. It allows marginalised individuals to connect and socialise, which helps them create and maintain identity. It promotes social identity and community engagement, which can empower marginalised individuals. Similarly, the activities of ethnic minority groups on internet platforms enable them to cultivate their ethnic identities and achieve valuable results.

The Internet has made it possible for LGBTQ people to meet other people who have had similar experiences, identities, and problems. People can find support, share stories, and discuss things on online boards, social media groups, and LGBTQ-specific websites. LGBTQ people can use these online groups to learn more about themselves and be comfortable with their identity, especially if they cannot access supportive offline networks. Thus, it allows LGBTQ people to connect with global movements and allies, which makes their opinions louder and helps them create an identity.

15.6.2 Power Relationships and Dynamics

Power dynamics are how power is shared, used, and fought over in political, social, and cultural processes. It includes the connections, hierarchies, and exchanges between people, groups, and institutions that affect how resources are used, decisions are made, and the ability to shape and control what happens. Understanding how power works in society and how it can be changed to fix unfairness and inequality requires understanding power relations.

The power relations (between powerful and powerless) in the real world can also be observed in the online world. However, the Internet can be used by marginalised people to challenge hegemonic narratives and present alternative perspectives, as it allows them to communicate directly with a global audience. This visibility can challenge stereotypes, break down barriers, and foster comprehension and compassion.

The Internet has also become a powerful tool for marginalised people to advocate for their rights and engage in activism. New interactive technologies are co-designed and modified by the user, providing user-generated content while extending control and power mechanisms beyond those predetermined by the capitalist system. Marginalised communities use these online channels to maintain and promote their cultural traditions, heritage, and artistic expression. They promote their cultural practices through videos, music, blogs, and social media while enhancing community pride and visibility. In addition, they use the Internet to express their concerns, draw attention to policy issues, and call for change.

15.6.3 Digital Participation

Internet-enabled technologies now play a critical role in participation. Individuals from marginalised groups produce and consume content that reflects their authentic voices and languages, their concerns and conditions, and issues pertaining to their development. People in marginalised groups often use digital tools to deal with social, economic, and political problems.

The digital technologies used by marginalised people for participation are as follows:

- **Community-driven websites and blogs:** websites and blogs that are run by the community. Many people in marginalised groups make their websites and blogs to share information, tools, and personal stories. These tools allow people to express themselves, build communities, and speak out.

- **Platforms for online activism:** Websites like Change.org and Avaaz let marginalised groups start and spread petitions, campaigns, and funding efforts. These tools help them make their voices heard and give them chances to work together.

- **Messaging apps:** Instant messaging apps like WhatsApp, Signal, and Telegram make it easier for marginalised groups to talk to each other and work together. They offer safe ways to share information, plan events, and get people to support a cause.

- **Online tools for learning:** Online educational materials made by certain groups (for instance, Sathali blogs by Santhal) include a variety of subjects that interest them, including mythology, novels, traditional knowledge, community history, and culture.

- **Digital storytelling platforms:** Platforms like YouTube, Vimeo, and podcasts are often used by marginalised groups to share their stories and experiences. They want to challenge established narratives and advance more inclusive representation by expressing their personal viewpoints and living experiences.

15.6.4 Indian Context

In some countries, marginalised groups are identified by government policy. Thus, the government of the country makes digital measures for those identified groups. The Indian government has undertaken many programmes to bridge the digital divide and provide marginalised populations access to the Internet and digital technologies. Digital India projects attempt to connect broadband to rural areas while increasing digital literacy among underserved people. Another measure is the multilingual portal 'Vikaspedia," which is being established as a single-window access to information, products, and services, with the explicit goal of addressing India's underprivileged groups.

15.7 VOICES FROM THE MARGIN

Marginalised communities use social media and other digital platforms to advocate for change and raise public awareness of social justice concerns. They share personal stories and confront discriminatory practices online through hashtags, viral videos, and online gatherings. Marginalised groups use social media platforms like Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram to share their stories, connect with people who share their views, and bring attention to their problems. People often use hashtags and online efforts to get people to help and raise awareness.

15.7.1 Online Activism by Marginalised Sections: Global Cases

There are several instances of marginalised populations worldwide using internet channels to actively engage in social concerns and campaign for their rights. Through social media and online campaigns, these groups have been able to reach more people, build support networks, and make changes on a global scale.

There are some global cases of online activism, as follows:

Racism: The #BlackLivesMatter movements started in the US but swiftly spread worldwide as activists used social media to disseminate awareness of institutionalised racism against Black communities. Using hashtags like #BlackLivesMatter, people could share their experiences, plan protests, and call for justice.

Sexual harassment: The actress Alyssa Milano is credited with starting the #MeToo movement, which inspired people to share their stories of sexual harassment and assault on social media. The campaign gained momentum on a global scale, sparking extensive discussions about sexual harassment in the workplace, gender-based violence, and the need for institutional reform.

Disability concerns: To promote accessibility, inclusiveness, and the rights of individuals with disabilities, activists from the disability rights movement have used digital platforms. Online movements like #DisabledandCute have expressed the viewpoints of people with disabilities.

15.7.2 Online Activism by Marginalised Sections: Indian Cases

In India, people from marginalised groups have used digital platforms to discuss social problems and fight for their rights.

There are some national cases of online activism, as follows:

Dalit activism: People from Dalit communities who face discrimination based on their caste have used digital media to bring attention to violence, discrimination, and social inequality based on caste. Online platforms like Dalit Camera and Round Table India share the views and experiences of Dalits to challenge caste-based oppression and fight for social justice.

Feminist movements: In India, internet platforms have been used by feminist activists to talk about gender inequality, violence based on gender, and discrimination. Online campaigns like #MeTooIndia and #AintNoCinderella have started conversations and raised the views of women, which has led to meaningful conversations about gender equality.

Tribal rights: Tribal communities in India have used internet platforms to fight for their rights, land, and traditional preservation. Online groups like Video Volunteers, Adivasi Lives Matter, and campaigns against illegal mining have used social media to bring attention to indigenous communities, record abuses, and fight for justice.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. What is digital marginalisation?

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2. How does the Internet help to create marginalised identity?

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3. Give two examples of digital participation by marginalised people.

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4. How do women in India use the Internet for online activism?

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15.8 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, we have learnt the causes, definitions, and dimensions of marginalisation, whether social, economic, or political. The cyber-optimistic and cyber-pessimistic views have been brought together to present holistic knowledge. The cyber-optimistic perspective on the Internet has been elaborated with the concepts of agency and identity, power dynamics, and digital participation. In contrast, the cyber-pessimistic perspective on the Internet has been discussed using the notions of digital marginalisation and digital media representation. There has been a reflection on the Indian scenarios of marginalisation, with particular reference to the Internet and digital tools.

Furthermore, the digital activism cases that can bring insight into national and international aspects have been discussed. We have also gained knowledge on the social theories incorporated into the concept of "internet and marginalisation." The unit has presented a fundamental understanding of the theories and practices of "internet and marginalisation" from multiple perspectives.

15.9 KEYWORDS

Marginality: Marginality refers to the condition of individuals or groups who are socially or economically marginalised, positioned on the edges of society, and lacking access to resources and opportunities, leading to exclusion and vulnerability.

Priming: Priming is the process through which media can impact people's thoughts and behaviours by triggering specific concepts or associations in their minds.

Framing: Framing in the media refers to the deliberate presentation or emphasis of specific aspects of an issue or event to influence the audience's understanding or interpretation of it, thereby influencing their opinions, judgments, and responses.

Media representation: Media representation is the depiction or portrayal of individuals, groups, events, or issues in media content, which influences how they are perceived, understood, and interpreted by the audience.

Digital Inequality: Digital inequality refers to the unequal access, availability, and utilisation of digital technologies and resources among individuals, groups, or communities, which leads to disparities in knowledge and opportunities.

Digital marginalisation: Digital marginalisation is the exclusion, disadvantage, or limited participation of individuals or groups in digital spaces and technologies, resulting in diminished access to digital information, resources, and opportunities.

15.10 FURTHER READING

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15.11 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. The process by which an individual or group is driven to the fringes or periphery of society, often resulting in their exclusion or limited participation in mainstream activities and decision-making processes, is referred to as "marginalisation".

2. Individuals at the intersection of multiple marginalised identities on digital platforms may face compounded forms of discrimination and marginalisation. For example, a person who is both a member of a racial group and a woman may face different kinds of exclusion in the digital space because of how race and gender interact.

3. Cyberoptimism praises the Internet as a free, interactive, and democratising medium. It argues that the rise of digital technology will lead to beneficial political, economic, and social shifts.

4. Marx's views on marginalised communities can be comprehended in his capitalism and class conflict concept. Marx examined society through the lens of economic relationships and unequal wealth and power distribution. It analyses the capital and power concentration within the digital economy. By analysing the concentration of digital capital and power, it is possible to comprehend how it moulds the digital landscape and exacerbates digital marginalisation by reinforcing class-based inequalities.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Digital marginalisation refers to exclusion or limited participation in the digital sphere, encompassing various technological and online-based aspects. Due to barriers, specific individuals or communities cannot completely access and benefit from digital technologies and online platforms.

2. The Internet allows marginalised individuals to connect and socialise, which helps them create and maintain identity. It promotes social identity and community engagement, which can empower marginalised individuals. Similarly, the activities of ethnic minority groups on internet platforms enable them to cultivate their ethnic identities and achieve valuable results.

3. Two examples of digital participation are: (i) Platforms for online activism: Websites like Change.org and Avaaz let marginalised groups start and spread petitions, campaigns, and funding efforts. These tools help them make their voices heard and give them chances to work together. (ii) Messaging apps: Instant messaging apps like WhatsApp, Signal, and Telegram make it easier for marginalised groups to talk to each other and work together. They offer safe ways to share information, plan events, and get people to support a cause.

4. Women have used Internet platforms to talk about gender inequality, violence based on gender, and discrimination. Online campaigns like #MeTooIndia and #AintNoCinderella have started conversations and raised the views of women, which has led to meaningful conversations about gender equality.

UNIT 16 CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK OF DIGITAL INEQUALITY

Structure

16.0 INTRODUCTION

The proliferation of information and communications technology (ICT) has given prominence to the digital divide discourse, which has become a subject of global concern. With the rise of new ICTs in the second half of the 1990s, the notion of the digital divide emerged in the policy context to address unequal access to digital technologies. All countries do not have the same ICT penetration or growth rate. Developing countries, particularly in Africa, Asia, and Latin America, often face significant challenges regarding access to digital infrastructure, affordability of digital devices, and availability of digital skills and knowledge. Although it has become hard to imagine life without the Internet and other forms of ICT, only some have the same access to devices such as phones, tablets, laptops, and desktop computers. Thus, the discussion over access to digital technologies has given rise to a debate over their usage from the standpoint of equality.

Simply put, digital inequality results from unequal access, skill, and use of the Internet and other ICTs. The conceptual framework for understanding digital inequality deals with the causes and consequences of digital inequality concerning ICTs, considering those as empowerment tools. Several disciplines contribute elements to the framework of digital inequality. Sociology emphasises social inequality regarding access to resources, control over different types of capital, and social involvement. Psychology examines problems as well as attitudes and reasons for using technology. Economics emphasises the spread of relevant innovations. Education deals with digital literacy, skills, and competence. Above all, communication studies deal with the tangents of mediated communication by constructing a connection between elements. Therefore, addressing the concept through the lens of communication studies requires a multi-faceted approach that involves sociological and technological perspectives intertwined with psychological, educational, and economic dimensions.

This Unit describes conceptual and theoretical patterns for identifying and understanding digital inequality using socio- and techno-centric accounts. Although only a small amount of theoretical study has been done so far on digital inequality, the Unit throws light on traditional as well as emerging concepts and frameworks that revolve around the rise of the digital divide, the manifestation of digital inequality, multiple concepts related to its components, and new forms of digital inequality.

16.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this chapter, you will be able to understand:

- multidimensionality of digital inequality;
- nuanced conceptual and theoretical approaches in the field of digital inequality;
- digital Inequality from a Sociological Perspective; and
- technological approach to digital inequality.

16.2 DIGITAL INEQUALITY: A SOCIAL PROBLEM

Neither the essences of individuals nor the essences of specific collectives or systems (such as capitalism or patriarchy) serve as the starting point for this idea of inequality (van Dijk, 2005). Instead, the idea of inequality is based on the connections, relationships, interactions, and transactions that exist between people. Therefore, digital inequality is a societal rather than a technical issue.

Access to digital technologies is necessary for participation in many aspects of life, including education, employment, healthcare, and social interaction. Individuals with limited access to digital technologies may find it difficult to fill out online job applications, communicate with potential employers, access online training resources, etc. Digital inequality is a social issue because it creates and expands social inequalities in education, employment, and information access. Those with limited access to digital technologies and skills may experience significant disadvantages in these areas, affecting their social and economic well-being.

Digital inequality can exacerbate other forms of social inequality, such as those based on race, gender, and socioeconomic standing. Those already marginalised in these areas may experience even more difficulty gaining access to and utilising digital technologies, which can exacerbate existing social disparities. As an example, in India, the digital gender gap encourages gender inequity. With internet connectivity, women may be included in employment opportunities, educational opportunities, and social networks, restricting their social mobility and economic desires. Digital inequality is a social concern because it creates and reinforces social inequalities, which can have long-term repercussions for individuals and society.

16.3 UNDERSTANDING THE CONCEPTUAL DEVELOPMENT

The term "digital divide" was not coined by any theorist; instead, it was first used in an official publication by the National Telecommunications and Information Administration (NTIA, 1999) in North America. In the earliest accounts of the phenomenon, the "digital divide" meant a disparity in the likelihood of having access to information and communication technologies (ICT) based on demographic characteristics such as race, gender, age, socioeconomic status, level of education, and the composition of the household. As the prevalence of computers and the Internet increased in developed nations, the discourse began to evolve, and more intricate conceptualisations were devised. In a short period, research on the digital divide has gained importance as an academic field; as a result, the concept of the "digital divide" has become more comprehensive with the emergence of "digital inequality".

16.3.1 Shift From Divide to Inequality

The term "digital divide" originally referred to the disparity between people with access to modern technologies and those without access (Van Dijk, 2005). This definition of the digital divide has been observed in terms of physical access to telephones, personal computers, cellular devices, etc. Later on, the definition became discordant with understanding the multidimensionality of communication beyond physical access to technologies. Moreover, it has become clear to social scientists that the digital divide is not related to a single type of binary gap but is intertwined with a range of social, economic, and technological issues. As soon as social scientists observed the nuances of digital access's social causes and consequences, the term got another social dimension called "inequality". According to this concept, the differences in access and usage of digital technologies are directly or indirectly related to social, cultural, political, and economic inequalities in society.

16.3.2 Dimensions of Digital Inequality

The digital divide laid the foundation for the concept of digital inequality. To understand the concept of digital inequality, one needs to understand the levels of the digital divide. Three levels of the digital divide correspond to multiple dimensions of digital inequality.

Table 1. The three levels of the digital divide

Levels	Deals With
First level	Binary access to ICTs (have or have not)
Second level	Digital skills
Third level	The tangible outcome of digital usage

Source: Author's compilation

The first level: The first level of the digital divide describes the unequal distribution of access to digital technologies. Low-income persons, those living in rural regions, people with impairments, and members of racial and ethnic minorities are disproportionately impacted by this divide.

Second level: The second level of the digital divide refers to the unequal distribution of digital skills and competence among people with access to digital technologies. This divide affects those with access to digital technologies but lacking the skills and competence to utilise them effectively. Individuals from low-income or marginalised communities may lack access to education or training in digital skills, resulting in the second level of the digital divide.

Third level: Access to digital devices and acquiring digital skills often fail to predict evenly distributed digital participation (meaningfully participating in the digital sphere). The third level of divide refers to the disparities in abilities to use digital technologies to achieve tangible outcomes of technology usage, such as online learning, remote work, e-commerce, and civic engagement.

16.3.3 Concept of Digital Inequality

The term "digital inequality" reflects a broader conception of the digital divide and incorporates a variety of factors beyond access to technology, including skills, usage patterns, and stakeholders involved in the acquisition of empowerment through technology. It acknowledges that more than merely providing access (binary access to digital technologies) to technology is required to ensure equal benefits from the opportunities it provides. Unequal access to economic, social, cultural, and personal resources impacts digital engagement (Helsper, 2012). Inequality may limit or boost citizens' social, economic, political, personal, and cultural capital, affecting their access to essential knowledge and ability to engage in society (Van Dijk, 2005). A range of determinants contribute to disparities in access to and use of digital technologies.

Table 2. Determinants of digital inequality

Socio-demographic	Age, gender, marital status, residency, living area
Economic	Income, employment status, employment type, occupational status, educational level
Social	Online social interaction, social networking, types of social activities
Cultural	Religion, ethnicity, internet use, language
Personal	Type of online activity language skills, English skills, cognitive function
Material	Internet access, access locations, number of electronic devices
Motivational	Attitude towards ICTs, internet motivation, frequency of internet use, time spent online

Source: Adapted from Scheerder, Deursen, & Dijjk (2017)

16.4 DIGITAL INEQUALITY AND CONTEMPORARY SOCIETY

The information and network society context best describes high-tech cultures of particular interest that cater to the digital environment. Scholars, including Manuel Castells and Jan van Dijk, used information and/or network societies to discuss disparities in ICTs. Although developed civilisations often display more information and network society features, discussing these concepts must be addressed in pursuing digital inequality, even in other sections of the world.

16.4.1 Inequality in Information Society

The idea of an information society broadly describes cultures in which information increasingly serves as both the primary input and output for all processes. Manuel Castells (2011) says that an information society is a type of social organisation in which information creation, processing, and transmission become the primary sources of productivity and power. Knowledge, information, and data continually expand and advance quickly in the information society. Inequality in the information society appears at the most fundamental level of information need, which leads to a widening gap in the capacity for association and knowledge transfer and in the capacity to judge the quality of information and make other related decisions. In modern times, there is a considerable disparity in the distribution of information abilities among different groups of people.

16.4.2 Inequality in the Network Society

The concept of network society is not synonymous with the concept of information society; instead, it is an extension of it. The notion of an information society emphasises the changing nature of activities and processes in modern developed nations. According to Castells (2011), the network society is an informational society in which networks serve as the core organisational structure and pervade all areas. Van Dijk (2006) characterised the network society as an information society shaped by a nervous system of social and media networks. Networks are formed when specific actors select others to join them. As a result, individuals or organisations are either included or removed. Being unable to connect to these networks entails complete exclusion and digital marginalisation.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. Explain the concept of "digital inequality".

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2. What are the levels of digital inequality?

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3. Mention any three essential determinants of digital inequality.

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4. How does inequality affect the information society?

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16.5 TECHNOLOGICAL APPROACH TO DIGITAL INEQUALITIES

Research-based theories and models help us make sense of complex ideas. Digital inequality, an interconnected and complex phenomenon, can be observed through various theoretical frameworks. Over the past decades, several theories regarding the unequal distribution of ICTs have emerged from studying their introduction, diffusion, and use. Theoretical frameworks for comprehending inequalities regarding how people adopt and integrate new technologies to be discussed include the Diffusion of Innovation Theory, the Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology (UTAUT), and the Resources and Appropriation Theory (RAT).

16.5.1 Diffusion of Innovation Theory

The diffusion of innovation theory was developed by E.M. Rogers in 1962 to describe how a community of potential customers adopts and spreads an innovation. This theory constructs the pattern by which new ideas, practises or products spread through a population. In this process of innovation and diffusion, diffusion occurs when individuals go through the steps of being aware of the need for an invention, deciding to adopt or reject the innovation, trying out the innovation for the first time, and then using the innovation regularly. Rogers divided adopters into five groups according to how long it took them to decide to adopt. The categories are innovators, early adopters, early majority, late majority, and laggards.

***Innovators*:** People willing to take risks are the first to try new ideas.

***Early adopters*:** Those eager to test the latest innovations and determine their application for everyone.

***Early majority*:** People from the general population who are the first to adopt new technology in the mainstream.

***Late majority*:** People from another part of the general population who follow the early majority and start using the new things in their everyday lives.

***Laggards*:** People who are slower to adopt new products and ideas. They are risk-averse and inflexible.

Each of the five types of adopters is affected by the five primary elements that influence innovation adoption, although to varying degrees: relative advantage, compatibility, complexity, trialability, and observability.

Relative advantage: The extent to which an innovation is perceived superior to the concept, product, or item it replaces.

Compatibility: The degree to which the innovation is consistent with the prospective adopters' values, experiences, and requirements.

Complexity: The difficulty in comprehending and/or implementing the innovation.

Trialability: The extent to which an innovation can be evaluated or experimented with prior to adoption.

Observability: The degree to which the innovation yields measurable outcomes.

Relevance in the pursuit of digital inequality: The theory may lack some ICT-specific modifications of components, but it is more robust to the diverse and constantly shifting complexities of technologies. Thus, it provides an understanding of the adoption of ICT over time or the diffusion of the Internet.

16.5.2 Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology (UTAUT)

In 2003, V. Venkatesh, M.G. Morris, G.B. Davis, and F.D. Davis proposed UTAUT by utilising popular models in the field of technology adoption. UTAUT is a popular framework for understanding how people adopt and use new technologies. It suggests that actual technology use is determined by behavioural intent. According to this theory, the perceived likelihood of adopting technology is directly influenced by four critical constructs: performance expectation, effort expectation, social influence, and enabling conditions. Age, gender, experience, and voluntariness moderate the effect of these indicators.

Components of the UTAUT include -

Performance expectation: This refers to the degree to which individuals perceive that a specific technology will assist them in performing their tasks more effectively or efficiently.

Effort expectation refers to the degree to which individuals assume that using a specific technology will be simple and require minimal effort.

Social influence: This refers to the extent to which individuals are influenced by the opinions and attitudes of others in their social networks, such as family, friends, and colleagues.

Enabling conditions: This refers to the extent to which individuals have access to the required resources and infrastructure, such as computers, internet connectivity, and technical support, to use a specific technology.

Relevance in the pursuit of digital inequality: Researchers have utilised the UTAUT to examine the factors that influence the adoption and use of digital technologies in communities with limited access in the context of the digital divide. Even though UTAUT has been widely utilised to characterise the digital gap, UTAUT and its components have been limited in characterising recent patterns of digital inequality.

16.5.3 Resources and Appropriation Theory

Jan van Dijk (2005) explained the resources and appropriation theory, addressing the social, cultural, and technological factors contributing to digital inequality.

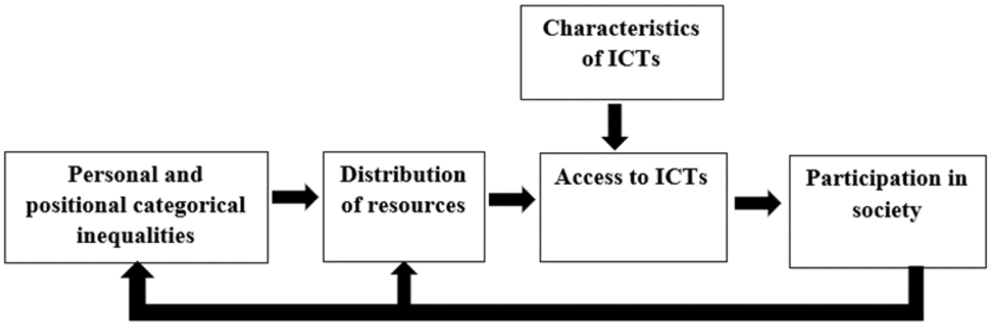

Figure 1. A Casual Model of Core Arguments
Source: Jan van Dijk (2005), The Deepening Divide

The core arguments of the theory are as follows:

- The unequal distribution of resources results from categorical inequalities in society.
- Unequal access to digital technologies results from an unequal distribution of resources.
- Unequal access to digital technologies is also influenced by the features associated with the technology.
- Unequal participation in society results from unequal access to digital technologies.
- Unequal distribution of resources and categorical inequalities are reinforced by unequal participation in society.

The components of the core arguments have been narrated as follows:

i) **Categorical inequalities:** Various personal and positional categories are accountable for the unequal distribution of resources required to access digital technologies. Personal categories comprise individual traits such as age, sex, race, intelligence (cognitive, emotional, and social), and personality (introvert, extrovert, and others). Positional categories include stratifications in the following areas: household (parent-child, husband-wife), management-executive, developing-developed, urban-rural, citizen-migrant, and high-low education.

ii) **Resources and mechanisms of distribution:** An uneven access to digital technologies results from an unequal distribution of resources, where a few mechanisms (social exclusion, exploitation, and control) work throughout the process. The resources identified in theory are temporal (time to spend on different activities in life); material resources (income and all kinds of monetary properties); mental resources (knowledge, social, and technical skills, excluding digital skills); social resources (social network positions and relationships); and cultural resources (cultural status and all kinds of credentials).

iii) **Successive kinds of access:** The fundamentals of resources and appropriation theory explain the stages of digital appropriation, with motivation access being the first, material access being the second, and usage access following after skill access.

- Motivational access: Motivation refers to the factors, such as perceived utility and relevance, that influence people's interest in and engagement with digital technologies. Motivations vary from an attitude towards a particular digital medium to financial factors.
- Material or physical access: Material or physical access refers to the physical accessibility of digital technologies such as computers and the Internet. Time (whether one has time or not) and places (home, school, public places, etc.) to use digital tools and technologies all come under the umbrella of physical access.
- Skills access: Skill access refers to the digital literacy and skills required to utilise digital technologies and the Internet effectively. Skills that account for the usage of digital media encompass operational (the skills needed to operate computers and internet connections), informational (skills used to search, select, and process information from computer and network sources), and strategic (skills to achieve personal or professional goals).
- Usage access: Usage access describes how individuals utilise digital technologies and the Internet, precisely, the intensity of usage time and diversity of applications.

iv) **Properties of ICT (Hardware, Software, and Content):** The degree to which a person accesses a particular ICT depends on its technological characteristics. Some of the properties of an ICT tool facilitate access, while others limit it. Complexity and expense limit access, while multifunctionality and network effects expand it. The formats of new media content are an essential characteristic that has a more significant impact on accessibility.

v) **Fields of participation in society:** In many parts of society, access to new media can mean the difference between being included and excluded. The umbrella term for these repercussions is participation in society. People with less exposure to digital media have steadily decreasing opportunities to participate in arenas such as citizenship, education, politics, culture, social interactions, and health care.

Relevance in the pursuit of digital inequality: Researchers have used resources and appropriation theory to comprehend digital inequality by analysing the distribution of resources and how individuals and groups appropriate and utilise them in the digital domain.

16.6 CONCEPTUAL DIMENSIONS FROM A SOCIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVE

Several traditional social theories serve as a background to the conceptual understanding of sociological approaches to digital inequality that can be used to probe its many facets and depths. Bourdieu's conceptions of capital and Weber's social stratification delve into the humanistic and social influences residing in digital inequality.

16.6.1 Bourdieusian Approach

Bourdieu (1986) defines capital as any resource that gives an individual an advantage that can be accumulated over time. Capital enables agents to replicate their positions within the social field and can take one of three fundamental forms: economic, cultural, or social capital, based on the arena in which it operates. In turn, each person's capital supports social inequality and social hierarchy. The conceptualisation of capital by Bourdieu has laid a foundation for a deeper understanding of digital inequality (Ragnedda & Ruiu, 2020).

In other words, people use and invest their social, cultural, and economic assets to strengthen their social status (symbolic capital). The capital of an individual not only creates the first level of the digital divide between those who can and cannot access the Internet but also the second level of the digital divide in terms of skill and capacity to use the Internet and the third level of the digital divide in terms of the social, economic, cultural, political, and personal advantages of being an internet user.

Bourdieu introduced the concept of social fields, structured spaces where individuals and groups compete for resources and power. In digital inequality, the digital realm can be considered a social field where individuals' engagement is influenced by their habitus—the internalised set of dispositions, behaviours, and preferences shaped by their social and cultural background. Digital inequality through the lens of social fields and habits allows an understanding of how individuals' social positioning and cultural capital influence their access to and use of digital technologies.

16.6.2 Weberian Approach

The Weberian approach, rooted in the sociological theories of Max Weber, can provide valuable insights into the intertwined processes between social and digital inequalities. Social inequalities as a potential topic of discussion in the discipline of digital inequality have been examined through the lens of Weber's social stratification and power dynamics. The Weberian approach to digital inequality uncovers the structural and systemic factors that contribute to digital inequality and guides efforts to mitigate disparities in access, skills, and resources in the digital realm.

Weber emphasised social stratification based on various dimensions, such as class, status, and power. Social stratification illuminates the manifested and circulated uneven distribution of resources. As per the concept, a group of people, being in a privileged position in society, take more advantage of ICTs and put them to use in achieving a tangible outcome (enhancement of life chances), such as job search, purchase, access to health care, political engagement, learning, socialisation, cybersecurity, leisure, and relationships with bureaucracy. As a result, different social groups, such as economically disadvantaged or marginalised communities, experience different levels (high to low) of access and benefits in the digital realm.

According to this approach, digital stratification intensifies on the following grounds:

Class: A class with limited capacity to use ICTs lacks the economic opportunities they offer.

Status group: A status group with limited capacities to use ICTs cannot serve the benefits of usage in status building, enhancement, and improvement.

Power: Limited capacities to use ICTs delimit personal interests, political power, and influence.

16.7 DIGITAL CAPITAL

Digital capital is the Bourdieusian approach to the digital realm. Following Bourdieu's concept of capital, digital capital is defined as the accumulation of both digital competence (internal skills and attitudes) and digital devices (external resources). It improves the tangible outcome of digital technologies to turn them into other forms of capital, such as social, economic, and cultural.

The core arguments for the concept are as follows:

- Digital capital is closely connected with economic, social, and cultural capital. A person needs these three capitals to build a good attitude and the right skills to use technology well.
- Digital capital is distributed unequally in society. Individuals with higher traditional forms of capital (such as education and social prestige) tend to have higher levels of digital capital. This indicates that people from more privileged backgrounds are more likely to have the skills, resources, and social connections necessary to flourish in the digital world. In contrast, less privileged people may struggle to access and utilise digital resources effectively.
- People need a network of support (social capital) like friends, family, and an online community to build up their digital capital. At the same time, people need money (economic capital) to access ICTs and knowledge, skills, and abilities (cultural capital) to use ICTs effectively.

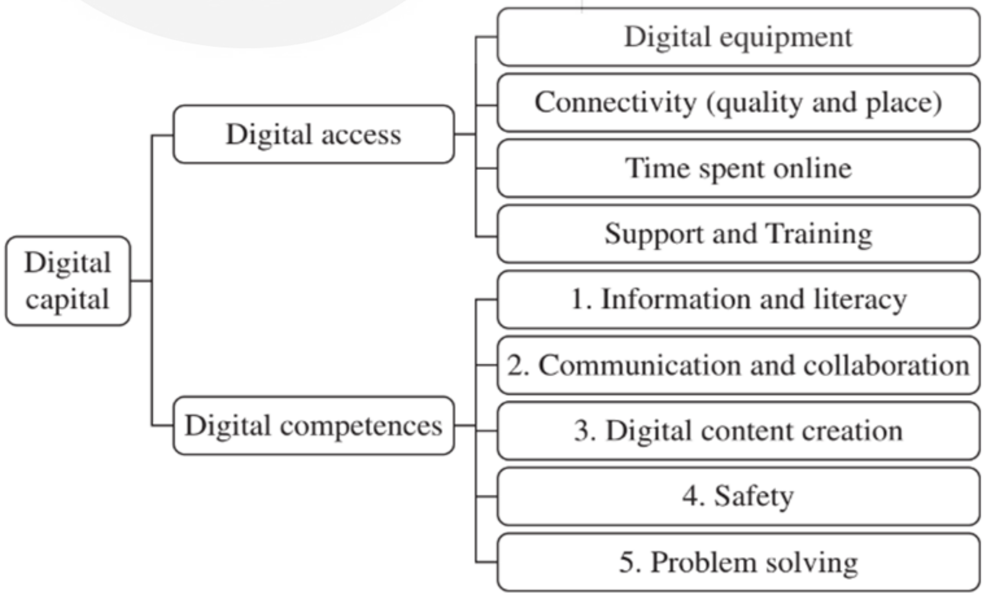

Figure 2. The Components of the Digital Capital Model

Source: Massimo Ragnedda and Maria Laura Ruiu (2020), Digital Capital: A Bourdieusian Perspective on the Digital Divide.

In 2020, Massimo Ragnedda and Maria Laura Ruiu proposed the model of digital capital. Digital competence and digital access are two distinct components of digital capital that can be built up and transferred to improve life chances. According to the concept, in an Internet-based society, digital capital joins the Bourdieusian capitals as an essential factor in illuminating the causes and consequences of social stratification and differentiation.

An individual's digital capital can be accessed by cumulating all the elements of digital access and digital competence. This model helps comprehend the patterns of digital inequality concerning the resourcefulness of digital capital. In simple words, it identifies digital capital inequality.

The elements of the core components have been described below:

Digital Access

Four elements of digital access:

i) Digital equipment: Devices used to access the Internet, such as mobile phones or smartphones, laptops, and desktop computers.

ii) Connectivity: Access quality depends on which setting is used to access the Internet.

iii) Time spent online: Cumulative experience in using ICTs in terms of total time of internet usage (years of usage)

iv) Support: Seeking help to support experiences related to digital technology

Digital competence

i) Competence Area 1: Information and Literacy
   - The activities of browsing, searching, filtering, data, information, and digital content
   - Evaluating data, information, and digital content
   - Managing data, information, and digital content

ii) Competence Area 2: Communication and Collaboration
   - Interacting through digital technologies
   - Engaging in citizenship
   - Sharing and collaborating through digital technologies
   - Managing digital identity

iii) Competence Area 3: Digital Content Creation
   - Developing, integrating, and re-elaborating digital content
   - Knowledge about copyright and licences
   - Programming

iv) Competence Area 4: Safety
   - Protecting devices, personal data and privacy
   - Protecting health and well-being and the environment

v) Competence area 5: Problem-solving

- Solving technical problems, identifying needs and technological responses
- Identifying digital competence gaps

16.8 DIGITAL INCLUSION - EXCLUSION AND PARTICIPATION

Digital inclusion refers to the efforts and initiatives aimed at ensuring that all individuals, regardless of socioeconomic background, geographic location, age, gender, or ability, have equal access to and opportunity to use digital technologies effectively. Digital inclusion efforts may involve:

- Increasing internet access
- Bridging the digital skills gap
- Access to digital devices
- Creating digital content
- Addressing affordability
- Empowering marginalised communities
- Policy and regulatory interventions

Digital exclusion is when individuals or groups are systematically excluded from accessing and utilising digital technologies and resources, resulting in a lack of participation in the digital world.

The digital participation of individuals assures the digital inclusion of an individual and, on a larger scale, a specific group or community. In this context, participatory inequality, which may be defined as people's inability to use the Internet to produce and disseminate digital resources, is a potential barrier to the growth of a network society.

Table 3. Areas of participatory inequality

Area	Inequality
Economic participation	Inequalities regarding the usage of ICTs to participate in the labour market and business
Educational participation	Inequalities regarding educational usage of ICTs
Social participation	Inequality in the field of social capital building (e.g., building social networks)
Cultural participation	Inequality related to online cultural practices
Political participation	Inequality over the Online political discourse
Institutional participation	Inequality in achieving digital citizenship

Source: Adapted from Jan van Dijk (2005)

To eradicate digital exclusion, stakeholders (governments, organisations, and local groups) must work together. Efforts to close the digital gap include building internet infrastructure, making devices and connections more affordable, providing digital skills training and literacy programmes, and creating digital platforms open to all users and meeting their different needs. These actions aim to ensure that everyone has the same chance to access and benefit from the digital world.

16.9 NEW FORMS OF DIGITAL INEQUALITY

The rapid advancement of technology has resulted in the emergence of new types of digital inequality, discussed as follows:

Privacy and digital inequality: Privacy concerns are more important than ever in the digital age. Those with more information, resources, and technological skills can protect their personal data by implementing privacy-enhancing methods and practices. On the other hand, people with little access to resources or digital literacy may be more at risk of privacy violations, data exploitation, or data hacking, which can increase inequality.

Algorithms and digital inequality: Everything from search engine results to automated decision-making systems depends heavily on algorithms. Internet users consciously or unconsciously deal with unseen infrastructure called an algorithm, logical rules, and technical prescriptions developed by programmers, mathematicians, and data engineers. Algorithms are essential for creating favourable conditions for participation in digital life; therefore, digital inequality arises from a lack of understanding of algorithms. Lack of awareness could negatively affect democracy and public involvement on a societal level.

Artificial intelligence (AI) and digital inequality: Automation and other emerging technologies like artificial intelligence (AI) have the potential to produce new types of inequality. Access to and proficiency with these technologies can lead to increased productivity, better career possibilities, and financial gains. However, those people and communities that do not have the digital literacy to adapt to these disruptive technologies may be excluded from these advantages, which would increase inequality.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. Explain the Weberian approach to digital inequality.

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2. What are the core arguments of "Resources and Appropriation Theory"?

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3. Write the definition of digital inclusion.

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4. What are the two components of the digital capital model?

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16.10 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, we gained a comprehensive understanding of digital inequality. It explained the factors contributing to inequality, such as disparities in access to technology, internet connectivity, digital skills, and usage factors. Delving into diverse frameworks of digital inequality, it defined the patterns and manifestations of digital inequality across different dimensions of academic disciplines. It also sheds light on how digital disparities intersect with factors like age, gender, race, ethnicity, income, and geographical location, how unequal access to digital resources and skills affects opportunities and outcomes, and possibilities to ensure equitable and secure digital environments as well. We learnt that the challenges faced by digital exclusion contribute to broader social and economic inequalities. We also explored new inequalities such as privacy, algorithmic, and AI-related inequalities. The discussion provided a deep understanding of the concept, offered diverse perspectives, and equipped you with knowledge and insights from a technological and sociological perspective of digital inequality.

16.11 KEYWORDS

Internet inequality: Internet inequality refers to the differences between people, communities, and nations regarding their capacity to access and efficiently use the Internet.

Digital inclusion: Digital inclusion refers to the inclusion of individuals and communities in the digital world, which means that they have access to digital technologies, internet connectivity, and the necessary skills to utilise them effectively and thus access to the economic, social, and cultural benefits of the digital world.

ICT: Information and communication technology (ICT) comprises diverse hardware, software, networks, and digital systems that allow for the processing, storage, transmission, and retrieval of data and information.

Digital participation: Digital participation is the active engagement, involvement, and inclusion of individuals and communities in the digital world through digital technologies to access information, communicate, create, collaborate, and contribute to digital content and platforms.

AI: Artificial intelligence (AI) refers to emulating human intelligence in machines programmed to carry out tasks that typically require human intelligence. It allows machines to perceive, reason, learn, and solve problems, enabling them to imitate or replicate human cognitive abilities.

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16.13 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. The term "digital inequality" reflects a broader conception of the digital divide and incorporates a variety of factors beyond access to technology, including skills, usage patterns, and stakeholders involved. It acknowledges that merely providing access (binary access to digital technologies) to technology is insufficient to ensure equal benefits from the opportunities it provides.

2. Three levels of the digital divide correspond to multiple dimensions of digital inequality. The first level of the digital divide describes the unequal distribution of access to digital technologies. The second level of the digital divide refers to the unequal distribution of digital skills and competence among people with access to digital technologies. The third level of divide refers to the disparities in individuals' abilities to use digital technologies to achieve tangible outcomes of technology usage.

3. Determinants of digital inequality include economic determinants - income, employment status, employment type, occupational status, and educational level; social determinants - online social interaction, social networking, types of social activities; cultural determinants - religion, ethnicity, and internet use language.

4. Inequality in the information society appears at the most fundamental level of information need, which leads to a widening gap in the capacity for association and knowledge transfer and the capacity to judge the quality of information and make other information-related decisions. In modern times, there is a considerable disparity in the distribution of information abilities among different groups of people.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Social inequalities as a potential topic of discussion in the discipline of digital inequality have been examined through the lens of Weber's social stratification and power dynamics. The Weberian approach to digital inequality uncovers the structural and systemic factors that contribute to digital inequality and guides efforts to mitigate disparities in access, skills, and resources in the digital realm.

2. Core arguments of the Resources and Appropriation Theory are (i) Unequal distribution of resources results from categorical inequalities in society. (ii) Unequal access to digital technologies results from an unequal distribution of resources. (iii) Their features also influence unequal access to digital technologies. (iv) Unequal social participation results from unequal access to digital technologies.

3. Digital inclusion refers to the efforts and initiatives to ensure that all individuals, regardless of socioeconomic background, geographic location, age, gender, or ability, have equal access to and opportunity to use digital technologies effectively.

4. Digital competence and digital access are two distinct components of digital capital that can be built up and transferred to improve life chances.

UNIT 17 GLOBAL MEDIA POLICIES

Structure

17.0 INTRODUCTION

You might have encountered issues like net neutrality, social media policy, media literacy for combating misinformation, and debates around free journalism and journalists. Much of it is influenced by the media and communication policy of the nation and the ones involved across the border. This is how media in China is different from media in Sweden.

Global media policies are a set of rules, regulations, and guidelines that govern the functioning and operations of media across national borders. The world is now increasingly interconnected. Hence, global media policies are pivotal in shaping the dissemination of information, promoting cultural diversity, and protecting the freedom of expression.

This Unit will provide you with a comprehensive understanding of global media policy, its historical context, key challenges and opportunities, relevant case studies, and the importance of promoting inclusive and diverse media environments worldwide.

17.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, you will:

- understand the importance of global media policy;
- acquire knowledge of the history and evolution of global media policy;
- be familiar with the organisations involved in global media policy;
- understand the challenges and opportunities in global media policy;
- discover prominent case studies related to global media policy;
- understand country-wise media policy approaches; and
- analyse the strengths, weaknesses, and implications of global media policies.

17.2 HISTORY AND EVOLUTION OF GLOBAL MEDIA POLICIES

17.2.1 A Brief History

The development of global media policies can be traced back to the early 20th century. It all began when international telecommunication agreements started emerging. The formation of the International Telecommunication Union (ITU) in 1865 laid the foundation for international cooperation in the field of communication.

However, it was in the mid-20th century that media policies gained significant attention.

The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) was pivotal in developing global media policies. In 1980, UNESCO adopted the "Many Voices, One World" report, also popular as the MacBride Report. It emphasised the importance of a free and pluralistic media system. The report highlighted the need to democratise global communication and reduce information imbalances between developed and developing countries.

17.2.2 Evolutionary Concerns in the Development of Global Media Policy

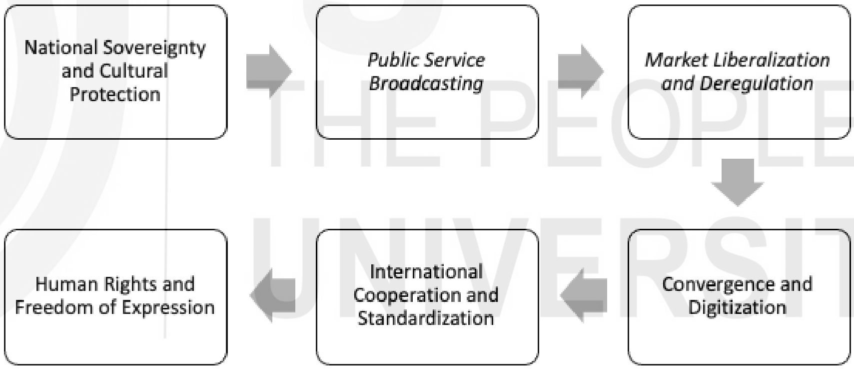
Over time, the Global Media Policy (GMP) approaches have evolved. It has been shaped by cultural, political, and technological contexts specific to each country or region. Understanding these historical approaches provides insights into the policy decisions and regulatory frameworks that have shaped today's global media and communication landscape.

1. ***National Sovereignty and Cultural Protection:*** In the early years of media regulation, many countries accentuated the protection of national sovereignty and cultural identity. They imposed restrictions on foreign media ownership, content importation, and the dissemination of information from external sources. The focus was to safeguard domestic media industries and preserve cultural values.

2. ***Public Service Broadcasting:*** The concept of public service broadcasting emerged in the early 20th century. This was a response to the rapid growth of commercial media. Countries like the United Kingdom and Canada introduced policies to establish public broadcasters. These were either funded by license fees or government subsidies. It aimed to provide educational, informative, and culturally enriching content while maintaining independence from political and commercial influences.

3. ***Market Liberalisation and Deregulation:*** In the late 20th century, there was a shift towards market-oriented policies. The belief in the benefits of competition and free markets drove this. Many countries undertook media deregulation, privatisation, and liberalisation. The aim was to reduce government control over media and promote market-driven approaches. These policies aimed to foster innovation, investment, and diversity in media industries.

4. ***Convergence and Digitisation:*** With the advent of digital technologies and the convergence of media platforms, new challenges and policy considerations emerged. Governments and regulatory bodies started revisiting traditional media regulations to manage the digital landscape effectively. Policies developed attempted to regulate online content, ensure net neutrality, protect user privacy, and promote access to digital communication services.



Evolutionary Concerns in GMP Development

5. ***International Cooperation and Standardization*****:** International cooperation became necessary with the globalisation of media and communication. Various international organisations, such as the United Nations, UNESCO, and the International Telecommunication Union (ITU), facilitated dialogue, collaboration, and the development of common standards and principles—international agreements, conventions, and guidelines materialised to promote cross-border cooperation. Endeavours to tackle global challenges like cybersecurity and the digital divide also surfaced.

6. ***Human Rights and Freedom of Expression:*** The recognition of freedom of expression as a human right influenced the development of media policies. International human rights frameworks, such as the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and regional human rights conventions, provided a foundation for advocating media freedom, access to

information, and protecting journalists' rights. These principles are mirrored in media policy approaches worldwide.

Activity 1: Go through the Media policy document of your country.

- What concerns could you spot in the media policies?
- What is the latest approach in the contemporary media policy debates?

17.3 BROAD CLASSIFICATION OF MEDIA POLICIES

17.3.1 Content-Carriage Categorisation

Media and communication policies can be categorised based on the message and vehicle. This approach will help you to identify different aspects of the regulatory framework. Here's an elaboration on each:

A. ***Content Policies**:* Content policies focus on regulating the material disseminated through media and communication channels. These policies typically aim to balance protecting freedom of expression and addressing concerns about harmful, offensive, or illegal content. Such policies deal with:

→ Censorship and Content Restrictions: Governments may restrict certain types of content, such as hate speech, incitement to violence, or pornography. These policies vary across jurisdictions. The extent of restrictions imposed can impact freedom of expression significantly.

→ Broadcasting Standards: Policies may set standards for broadcast content, including guidelines for appropriate language, violence, and nudity. Regulatory bodies often enforce these standards. Additionally, they may have mechanisms for receiving and addressing complaints from the public.

→ Public Service Broadcasting: Policies might promote the existence of public service broadcasting to provide programming that serves the public interest and diverse communities. These policies often outline the funding mechanisms and programming obligations for public broadcasters.

→ Classification and Age Restrictions: Policies may establish systems for classifying media content, such as movies, TV shows, and video games, based on their suitability for different age groups. These classifications help parents and consumers about the content's appropriateness.

B. ***Carriage Policies**:* Carriage policies pertain to regulating the infrastructure and means by which media content is transmitted. These policies often focus on promoting fair competition, access to information, and ensuring the reliability and availability of communication services. Carriage policies can include:

→ Telecommunications Regulation: Policies may govern the telecommunications industry by licensing telecommunications service providers, spectrum allocation, and technical standards. These policies aim to ensure reliable and accessible communication services.

→ Net Neutrality: Net neutrality policies aim to ensure equal and non-discriminatory treatment of internet traffic by internet service providers (ISPs). These policies prevent ISPs from blocking, throttling, or prioritising certain online content or services. It also ensures an open and level playing field on the Internet.

→ Universal Service Obligations: Policies may impose obligations on service providers to ensure universal access to communication services, particularly in underserved or remote areas. This includes provisions for affordable and accessible telephony, broadband, and other essential communication services.

→ Interconnection and Access: Policies may regulate the interconnection between different communication networks. This is done to ensure fair and non-discriminatory access to network infrastructure. These policies aim to promote competition and prevent anti-competitive practices.

**Note- Policies within each category can vary significantly across different countries and jurisdictions, reflecting the unique social, cultural, and political contexts in which they are developed.*

Activity 2

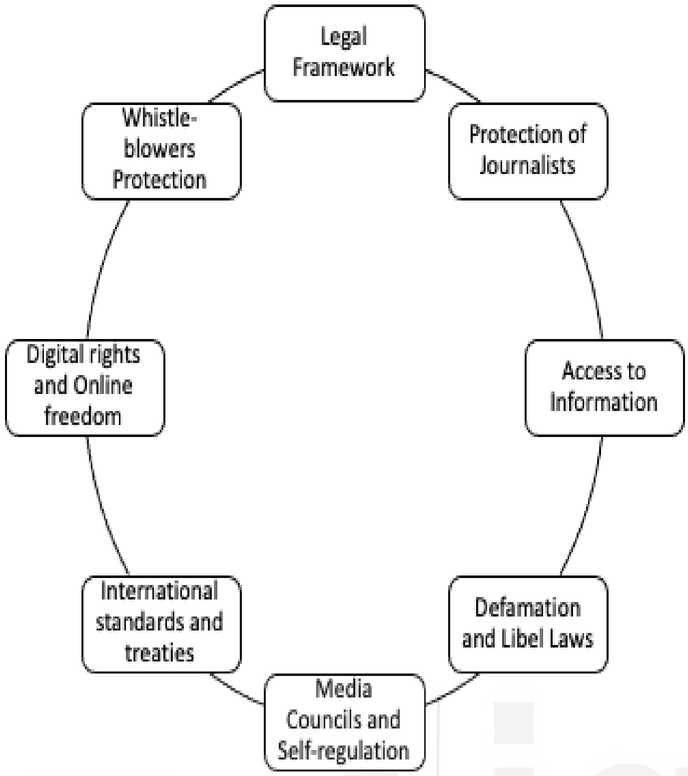
1. How does age group censor movies in your country?
   a. Are there categories for it?
   b. Who is responsible for issuing these certificates to films?
2. Try to find out about the Universal Service Obligation Fund (USOF) and the various initiatives under it.

17.3.2 Based on the Functional Dimensions

Media Policies can also be categorised into key areas that can help understand global media policies' functional dimensions.

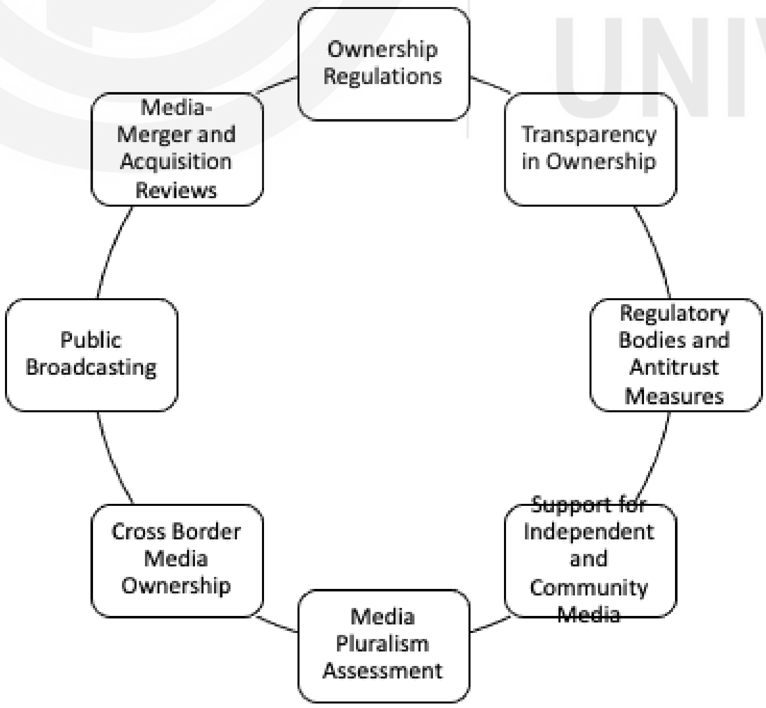
These categories provide a framework to help you understand the multifaceted nature of global media policies. However, it is important to note that these categories are not mutually exclusive, and policies often intersect across multiple areas.

A. ***Freedom of Expression and Press Freedom:*** As you might have guessed, these policies promote and protect the freedom of expression and the press. They encompass laws, regulations, and practices that ensure individuals and media organisations can freely express their views, opinions, and ideas without undue censorship or restrictions. These policies also aim to safeguard journalists, combat impunity for crimes against journalists, and promote media pluralism.



Policy Issues related to Freedom of expression and Press Freedom

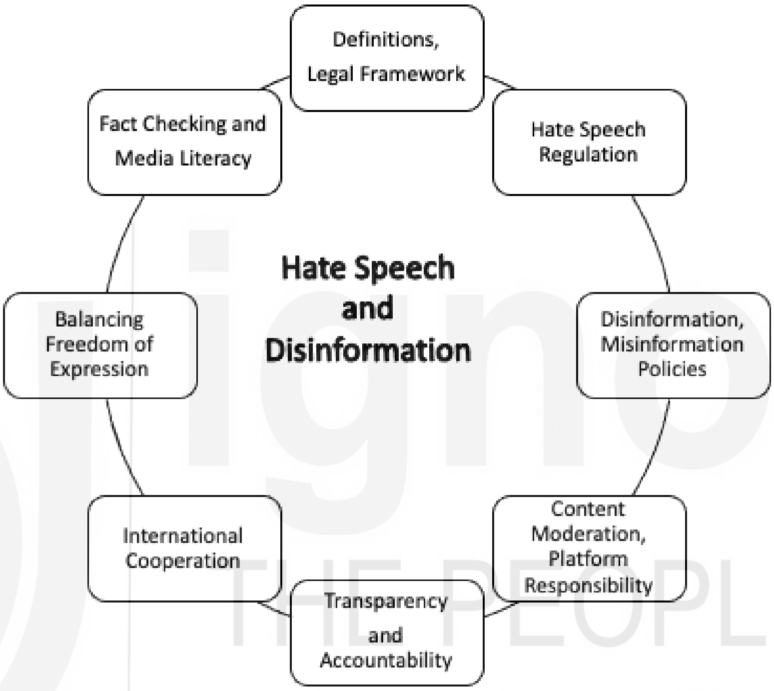
B. ***Media Ownership and Concentration:*** The policies related to media ownership and concentration fall under this category. It aims to ensure a diverse and pluralistic media landscape. They aim to prevent monopolistic practices, regulate cross-media ownership, and promote transparency in media ownership structures. This would ensure undue control of media outlets by a few entities, facilitating a wide range of voices and perspectives.



Policy Issues Related to Media Ownership and Concentration

C. ***Media Pluralism and Diversity:*** These policies promote diverse and inclusive media ecosystems. They promote representation of various cultural, ethnic, social, and linguistic groups and platforms for marginalised voices. They try to achieve it through measures to counteract discrimination, support community media, and foster content diversity.

D. ***Regulation of Hate Speech and Disinformation:*** These policies seek to combat the spread of harmful content through hate speech, disinformation, and misinformation while balancing the right to free expression. They promote identifying and addressing hate speech, fact-checking, and transparency in online platforms.



Policy Issues Related to Hate Speech and Media Disinformation

E. ***Privacy and Data Protection:*** With increasing digitisation, privacy and data protection policies have become critical. These policies focus on safeguarding individuals' data, ensuring consent-based data practices, and protecting privacy rights in the digital realm. They deal with regulations on data collection, storage, and usage by media organisations and online platforms.

F. ***Internet Governance and Net Neutrality:*** Internet governance policies address the regulation and management of the Internet. It comprises issues such as net neutrality, cross-border data flows, cybersecurity, and digital rights.

G. ***Media Literacy and Education:*** Policies in this category aim to promote media literacy and education among citizens. They focus on equipping individuals with the skills to critically analyse and evaluate media content, fostering media literacy in schools, and promoting digital literacy to navigate the complex media landscape.

H. ***Copyright and Intellectual Property*****:** Policies related to copyright and intellectual property address the protection of creative works, including media content. These laws and regulations govern the rights of creators, fair use, and copyright infringement. A balance between intellectual property protection and access to information is a parallel concern of these policies.

Activity 3

Go through the important updates related to media policy in the last year

- Nationally
- Internationally

What functional dimensions do you find

17.4 GLOBAL MEDIA POLICY LANDSCAPE

Each country has distinctive media policies shaped by cultural, political, and social contexts. For example, the United States strongly emphasises freedom of speech and limited government intervention. In contrast, countries like China have a more controlled media landscape with censorship and strict regulations.

17.4.1 Power Dynamics in GMP

Several countries have historically had significant hegemony in shaping global media and communication policies. Here are some notable examples:

A. **United States**: The United States has dominated in shaping global media policies. With a robust media industry, technological advancements, and multinational media corporations, the US has been influential in setting standards, content distribution practices, and industry regulations. The country's policies, including those related to intellectual property, copyright, and trade, have had a global impact on media and communication.

B. **United Kingdom**: The United Kingdom has played a crucial role in shaping global media policies, particularly during colonialism and the expansion of British media networks. The BBC's model of public service broadcasting, with its emphasis on quality programming and educational content, has influenced media policies in many countries. Additionally, the UK has been active in international organisations and forums that address media regulation and industry practices.

C. **Germany**: with its strong media industry and cultural influence, Germany has been influential in shaping media policies within the European Union (EU) and globally. The country has advocated for the protection of cultural diversity and media pluralism. Its hate speech and privacy regulations have influenced discussions on those topics worldwide.

D. **France**: France has actively promoted cultural diversity and media pluralism globally. The country has advocated for policies that protect and support local content production, particularly in France. France has been vocal in pushing for regulations on digital platforms, including measures to protect copyright and combat disinformation.

E. **China**: In recent years, China has influenced global media policies, particularly concerning its domestic media market and technological advancements. China's approach to media regulation, censorship, and control over information flow has been influential within its borders. It has raised discussions about the impact of Chinese media policies on the international media landscape.

Contrary to this, several countries have been marginalised to varying degrees in global media and communication policies. Marginalisation can occur in different ways and to different extents. Here are a few examples of countries that have faced challenges in terms of representation, access, and influence in the global media landscape:

A. Developing Countries: Many developing countries, particularly those with limited economic resources and technological infrastructure, face significant challenges in participating fully in global media and communication policies. These countries often struggle with limited access to advanced technologies, internet connectivity, and digital media platforms, which hinders their ability to compete and contribute to the global media market.

B. Small Island States: Small island states, particularly those in the Pacific and the Caribbean, often face marginalisation due to their geographical isolation and limited resources. These countries may have small populations, which makes it challenging to sustain a thriving media industry and gain international visibility. They also face vulnerabilities related to climate change, which can further limit their ability to participate in global media and communication policies.

C. Non-English Speaking Countries: Countries where languages other than English are predominantly spoken can face challenges in global media policies. English has a dominant presence in international media, and countries with different languages may face barriers regarding language accessibility, translation, and dissemination of their content to a broader audience. This can result in limited international visibility and influence.

D. Conflict-Affected Countries: Countries experiencing conflicts or political instability often face significant challenges in shaping media policies and ensuring access to free and independent media. Governments may restrict media freedom, limiting representation and diverse perspectives in the global media landscape.

E. Indigenous Communities: Indigenous communities worldwide often face marginalisation in global media and communication policies. Their voices, languages, and cultural expressions are often underrepresented or overlooked in mainstream media. This marginalisation can perpetuate stereotypes, cultural erasure, and limited access to media platforms to share their stories and perspectives.

17.4.2 Key Organisations for GMP

Several international organisations have contributed to shaping global media policies. A few key organisations are:

→ The International Telecommunication Union (ITU), a specialised agency of the United Nations, focuses on global telecommunication standards and policies.

→ The World Trade Organization (WTO) also significantly regulates media and communication services trade.

→ Additionally, through bodies like UNESCO, the United Nations (UN) promotes media development and advocates for press freedom.

→ Regional organisations such as the European Union (EU), African Union (AU), and the Organization of American States (OAS) also contribute to the formulation of regional media policies.

17.4.3 Recent Influences on GMP

Several incidents have influenced global media policies.

→ The Net Neutrality debate, particularly in the United States, has led to dialogues on equal access to online content and preventing internet service providers from favouring some websites or services.

→ The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) enforced by the European Union has set a precedent for data privacy and protection globally. It has driven organisations to prioritise user consent, transparency, and the secure handling of personal data.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. Describe the history and evolution of global media policies. How has the development of these policies been influenced by the changing media landscape and technological advancements?

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2. Classify global media policies based on content-carriage categorisation and functional dimensions. How do these classifications help in understanding the diverse approaches adopted by countries?

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3. Analyse the power dynamics involved in global media policies. How do global organisations and key stakeholders influence the formulation and implementation of these policies?

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Activity 3

Did you come across any net neutrality debate lately? If yes, what was it about? If not, then try to find out the discussions about it at the national and international levels.

17.5 GLOBAL MEDIA POLICY EVALUATION

17.5.1 Research Organisations and GMP

Research offers a wealth of information on global media policy. Research, reports, case studies, and analyses can serve as valuable references for understanding the evolving landscape of media policy worldwide.

A. **Global Media Policy Observatory (GMPO):** The GMPO is a research and knowledge hub offering worldwide insights and analysis on media policy issues. It provides research papers, reports, and resources on various aspects of global media policy.

   Website: https://www.gmpo.org/

B. **International Telecommunication Union (ITU):** The ITU is a specialised agency of the United Nations responsible for setting global telecommunications standards and policies. Their website offers publications, reports, and databases related to media policy and regulation.

   Website: https://www.itu.int/

C. **United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO):** UNESCO promotes freedom of expression, media development, and the safety of journalists. Their website provides resources, publications, and reports on global media policy and press freedom.

   Website: https://en.unesco.org/

D. **Global Forum for Media Development (GFMD):** A network of media support organisations working towards media development and pluralism. Their website offers research papers, policy briefs, and global media policy issues resources.

   Website: https://gfmd.info/

E. **Center for International Media Assistance (CIMA):** A project of the National Endowment for Democracy, focuses on media development and freedom globally. Their website provides reports, publications, and media policy and regulation analysis.

   Website: https://www.cima.ned.org/

F. **Reporters Without Borders (RSF):** An international organisation advocating for press freedom and protecting journalists. Their website offers the World Press Freedom Index, reports, and resources on media freedom and media policy.

   Website: https://rsf.org/

G. **Global Digital Policy Incubator (GDPI):** Based at Stanford University, it explores the intersection of technology, policy, and governance. Their website provides research papers, articles, and resources on global digital policy, including media policy.

   Website: https://fsi.stanford.edu/gdpi

H. **Global Media Policy Project (GMPP):** A global research initiative focusing on global media policy and regulation. They provide publications, blog posts, and resources on various media policy issues.

   Website: https://www.globalmediapolicy.net/

17.5.2 Performance Indexes Related to GMP

Global media policies are indexed through various indicators. Several organisations produce annual rankings and reports assessing countries' performance related to media policies and press freedom. Here are some rankings for you to refer to:

A. **World Press Freedom Index (Reporters Without Borders):** The World Press Freedom Index ranks countries based on press freedom and ease of journalism. It evaluates factors such as media pluralism, transparency, legal framework, censorship, and the safety of journalists. The index is widely recognised and respected.

   Website: https://rsf.org/en/ranking

B. **Freedom of the Press Index (Freedom House):** The Freedom of the Press Index assesses press freedom and media independence in countries worldwide. It considers the legal environment, political pressures, economic influences, and violence against journalists. This index provides a comprehensive analysis of media freedom.

   Website: https://freedomhouse.org/report-types/freedom-press

C. **Media Sustainability Index (IREX):** The Media Sustainability Index reports the health and viability of media systems in different countries. It assesses factors like legal environment, infrastructure, professionalism, business management, and supporting institutions. The index provides insights into the overall sustainability of media sectors.

   Website: https://www.irex.org/msi

D. **Digital Rights Ranking (Digital Rights Foundation):** The Digital

Rights Ranking assesses countries based on their legal framework, practices, and policies concerning digital rights, including freedom of expression, privacy, and access to information. It focuses on the digital landscape and its impact on human rights.

Website: https://digitalrightsfoundation.pk/digital-rights-ranking/

E. **Media Development Indicators (UNESCO):** UNESCO's Media Development Indicators provide a framework for assessing the status of media development in countries. The indicators cover areas such as media pluralism, diversity of content, professional capacity, and legal and regulatory frameworks. It provides a comprehensive overview of the media landscape in a country.

Website: https://en.unesco.org/themes/mediadevelopment/assessments/mdi

17.5.3 Countries with a Strong Commitment to GMP

Determining the countries with the best media and communication policies is subjective and can vary depending on different criteria and assessments. However, several countries have been recognised for their strong commitment to media freedom, information access, and policies promoting a diverse and vibrant media landscape. Here are a few examples:

A. **Norway:** Norway is often regarded as a leader in media freedom and press freedom. The country consistently ranks high in global media freedom indexes, emphasising a strong legal framework that protects freedom of expression, an independent media sector, and robust public service broadcasting.

B. **Finland:** Finland is known for its strong media policies that promote transparency, access to information, and freedom of the press. The country has a vibrant media landscape with a strong public service broadcasting system and high media literacy.

C. **Sweden:** Sweden is recognised for its progressive media policies and commitment to media freedom. The country strongly emphasises freedom of expression and transparency, with a legal framework that protects journalists and promotes independent media.

D. **Netherlands:** The Netherlands is often lauded for its media policies that support a diverse and independent media sector. The country promotes media pluralism, freedom of expression, and access to information. It has a strong public broadcasting system and an active media watchdog to ensure media integrity.

E. **Costa Rica:** Costa Rica is notable for its strong commitment to press freedom and access to information. The country has a legal framework that protects freedom of expression and a history of fostering independent media and promoting media diversity.

17.5.4 Countries Facing Challenges with GMP

Certain countries have been consistently ranked low regarding media freedom and press freedom by organisations such as Reporters Without

Borders (RSF) and Freedom House. Countries with significant challenges in media policy and restrictions on freedom of expression include:

A. **North Korea:** North Korea consistently ranks at the bottom of various media freedom indexes due to its highly restrictive media environment, government control over all forms of media, censorship, and limited access to information.

B. **Eritrea:** Eritrea is often regarded as one of the most repressive countries regarding media freedom. The government exercises strict control over the media, with no independent media outlets allowed, and journalists face harassment, imprisonment, and censorship.

C. **Turkmenistan:** Turkmenistan is known for its strict media controls and limited freedom of expression. The government maintains tight control over all forms of media, and self-censorship is common among journalists due to fear of reprisals.

D. **China:** China has extensive media controls and censorship mechanisms, including the Great Firewall, which restricts access to foreign websites and social media platforms. The Chinese government tightly controls traditional and online media, and critical journalism is often met with censorship, imprisonment, and other forms of repression.

E. **Saudi Arabia:** Saudi Arabia has a restrictive media environment with limited freedom of expression. The government controls traditional media outlets, and independent journalism is suppressed. Journalists critical of the government have faced intimidation, imprisonment, and violence.

**Note - No country is perfect; countries with strong media policies may face challenges and ongoing debates in certain areas. Media policy rankings can change over time and the assessment of media freedom is a complex and multifaceted issue.*

17.6 GLOBAL MEDIA POLICIES: CHALLENGES AND OPPORTUNITIES

There are many challenges for Global media policies in the contemporary world.

→ With the rise of social media and online platforms, issues such as disinformation, hate speech, and privacy have become prominent concerns. Hence, one of the challenges is striking a balance between the free flow of information and the regulation of harmful content.

→ Another challenge lies in ensuring media diversity and representation. The concentration of media ownership and control in the hands of a few powerful entities can limit the plurality of voices and perspectives. Bridging the digital divide and ensuring access to information for all, especially in developing countries, is still challenging.

Despite the challenges, global media policies also present opportunities for positive change.

Digital media, as you know, has enabled greater participation and citizen journalism, allowing diverse voices to be heard. The growth of online platforms provides a space for independent media outlets and content creators, facilitating media pluralism.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. Identify key organisations involved in shaping global media policies. How do these organisations collaborate and cooperate to address issues concerning media regulation and freedom of expression?

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2. Evaluate the recent influences on global media policies. How have factors like technological advancements, geopolitical shifts, and emerging media platforms impacted policy-making in the digital age?

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3. Discuss the challenges and opportunities in global media policies. How can international cooperation and policy innovation address the challenges while maximising the opportunities for a diverse and inclusive global media landscape?

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17.7 LET US SUM UP

Global media policies continue to evolve along with technological advancements and societal changes. Balancing the freedom of expression with the need for regulation is challenging.

But there are also opportunities to promote transparency, inclusivity, and cultural diversity in the media landscape.

International organisations, governments, and civil society must collaborate and adopt policies that foster a free, pluralistic, and responsible media ecosystem on a global scale.

17.8 KEYWORDS

Net Neutrality: Equal access to online content and prevents discrimination by Internet service providers

Media Pluralism: Media pluralism refers to the presence of diverse and independent media outlets that offer a variety of perspectives, opinions, and voices within a given media system.

17.9 FURTHER READINGS

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17.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. The history of global media policies dates back to the early regulations of telegraph and radio. Over time, the evolution of media technologies, like the internet, has driven policy changes to address new challenges, such as digital content distribution and cross-border media flows.
2. Global media policies can be classified based on content-carriage categorisation (content regulation vs. infrastructure regulation) and functional dimensions (regulation for economic, social, or political objectives). These classifications aid in comprehending how different nations approach media governance.
3. Influential organisations, governments, media conglomerates, and civil

society actors shape power dynamics in global media policies. They exert their influence through lobbying, international agreements, and strategic alliances to advance their interests and agendas.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Key organisations like UNESCO, WTO, and ITU significantly shape global media policies. They collaborate through multilateral discussions, setting standards, and facilitating cooperation to address media-related challenges and promote freedom of expression.

2. Recent influences on global media policies include internet governance debates, data privacy concerns, and the rise of digital platforms. Technological advancements, geopolitical tensions, and the growing role of social media platforms have transformed policy-making to address the challenges posed by the digital age.

3. Challenges in global media policies include balancing media freedom and regulation, combating misinformation, and addressing digital divides. Opportunities lie in promoting diversity and inclusivity, fostering international cooperation, and developing innovative policies that keep pace with rapid technological changes while safeguarding human rights and democratic values.

UNIT 18 INTERNET GOVERNANCE

Structure

18.0 INTRODUCTION

The history of Internet governance spans several decades and is quite interesting. Technological advancements, policy debates, and the evolution of global collaboration characterise it. This section will discover the key milestones and significant events that have shaped Internet governance.

18.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, you will be able to:

- outline the history of Internet governance;
- analyse the importance of Internet governance;
- explore critical organisations involved in Internet governance;
- discuss landmark decisions and policies that have influenced Internet governance globally;
- analyse internet governance in the context of a specific country, such as India;
- investigate conflicts and challenges related to Internet governance; and
- examine notable civic movements and advocacy efforts in the field of Internet governance.

18.2 HISTORY OF INTERNET GOVERNANCE

18.2.1 The Emergence of the Internet

The attempts at Internet governance can be traced back to the humble beginnings of computer networking. In the 1960s, the Advanced Research Projects Agency (ARPA) of the United States Department of Defense, in groundbreaking work, developed ARPANET. This was a network that connected computers at various research institutions. This laid the foundation for the development of the Internet.

18.2.2 Informal Governance

The existing governance mechanisms were relatively informal when the Internet expanded in the 1970s and 1980s. Researchers and engineers collaborated through organisations like the Internet Engineering Task Force

(IETF) to develop and standardise protocols for Internet operation. The emphasis was on open participation and a bottom-up decision-making approach.

18.2.3 Formation of ICANN

The need for a more formalised governance structure became apparent as the Internet gained popularity and commercial significance in the 1990s. In 1998, the Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers (ICANN) was established as a nonprofit organisation domain name system (DNS) management, IP address allocation, and protocol parameters.

18.2.4 Role of the United States of America

One significant aspect of Internet governance has been the authority retention over the administration of the Internet's root zone file and the assignment of unique IP addresses under the National Telecommunications and Information Administration (NTIA) (an agency of the U.S. Department of Commerce).

18.2.5 Globalisation and Internationalisation

As the Internet became a global phenomenon, calls for a more international approach to govern the Internet grew louder. Hence, arguments concerning the inconsistency of the United States' unilateral control with the global nature of the Internet emerged. This led to efforts to take internet governance to an international level and increase the participation of other stakeholders' participation.

18.2.6 World Summit on the Information Society

In 2003 and 2005, the United Nations organised the World Summit on the Information Society (WSIS) to unite governments, civil society organisations, the private sector, and technical communities. The WSIS facilitated discussions on Internet governance, eventually forming the Internet Governance Forum (IGF), a multi-stakeholder forum for policy dialogue.

18.2.7 The Montevideo Statement and the IANA Transition

The year 2013 was a critical juncture regarding the role of the U.S. government in governing the Internet. The revelations of widespread surveillance activities by intelligence agencies stimulated the concern for a more globalised and decentralised governance model for the Internet. Consequently, various internet organisations, including ICANN, released the Montevideo Statement, expressing the need to accelerate the globalisation of ICANN to manage the internet infrastructure. This led to the emergence of IANA (Internet Assigned Numbers Authority) in 2016, transferring the control and management of the key Internet functions from the United States to the global Internet community.

Activity 1

Look for media reports on the Mass Surveillance of 2013 by the United States.

- How was this mass surveillance conducted?
- Was this a case of exploitation? If yes, how?
- How does it help to understand that Internet governance is important?

18.3 IMPORTANCE OF INTERNET GOVERNANCE

18.3.1 Stable and Secure Internet

Internet governance is crucial in ensuring a stable and secure global network. It does so by:

- establishing and enforcing technical standards and protocols,
- addressing cybersecurity threats and
- managing essential internet resources such as IP addresses and domain names.

Thus, Internet governance helps to maintain a reliable and secure digital infrastructure needed for a more connected world.

18.3.2 For an Open and Innovative Global Platform

An important feature of Internet governance is facilitating an open and innovative digital environment. It aims to do so through a policy framework that supports:

- net neutrality,
- freedom of expression,
- and fair competition.

It aims to be egalitarian by allowing individuals, businesses, and organisations to freely create, share, and access information and services on the Internet.

18.3.3 User Rights and Privacy

The prime concern of Internet governance is the rights and privacy of Internet users. Policies and regulations have been developed to:

- safeguard personal data,
- promote transparency, and
- provide mechanisms for redressal in case of violations.

This is aimed at building trust and maintaining the confidence of individuals in the digital world.

18.3.4 For Global Collaboration and Cooperation

The Internet's global reach requires international cooperation and collaboration among various stakeholders. Internet governance aids dialogue and coordination amongst:

- governments,
- civil society,
- technical communities, and
- the private sector.

This eventually helps to address common challenges, develop policies, and shape the future of the Internet collaboratively and inclusively.

Activity 2

Try to find out why the following are important internet resources.

- IP Address
- Domain Name System

18.4 KEY ORGANISATIONS IN INTERNET GOVERNANCE

18.4.1 Internet Governance Forum (IGF)

The World Summit on the Information Society (WSIS) resulted in the establishment of The Internet Governance Forum (IGF) in 2006. The IGF acts as a global platform for dialogue and collaboration on issues related to Internet governance. It convenes stakeholders from various sectors to:

- discuss policy-related issues,
- share best practices, and
- address emerging challenges in an egalitarian manner.

18.4.2 Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers (ICANN)

ICANN is a pivotal organisation for Internet governance. It manages domain names, IP addresses, and protocol parameters.

It follows a multi-stakeholder model, which promotes the participation of governments, the private sector, technical experts, civil society organisations, and individual internet users.

ICANN plays a pivotal role in ensuring the stability and security of the Internet through its policies and decisions that shape the domain name system worldwide.

IGF Internet Governance Forum	ICANN
IETF	W3C World Wide Web consortium

Key Organisations for Internet Governance

18.4.3 Internet Engineering Task Force (IETF)

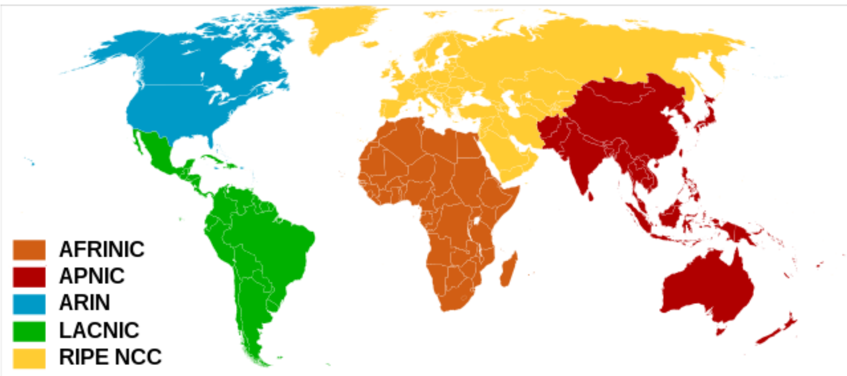
The Internet Engineering Task Force (IETF) is a community comprising technical experts, engineers, and researchers across the globe. IETF is concerned with the development and standardisation of Internet protocols. The IETF also tries to ensure operability and seamless communication across networks. Through an open and collaborative process, the IETF produces standards based on consensus that guide the functioning of the Internet worldwide.

18.4.4 World Wide Web Consortium (W3C)

The World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) is an international community to develop the standards for the World Wide Web. Tim Berners-Lee, the inventor of the web, has led it. It tries to ensure the World Wide Web remains open, accessible, and interoperable. W3C has played a significant role in shaping the evolution of the web by developing and promoting technical specifications and guidelines for it.

18.4.5 Regional Internet Registries (RIRs)

Regional Internet Registries (RIRs) are responsible for the allocation and management of IP addresses within specific regions all around the world. There are five RIRs worldwide, each serving a designated geographical area. To ensure an efficient allocation and distribution of IP addresses in a specific region, the registries work closely with network operators, internet service providers, and other stakeholders of that region.



Map of Regional Internet Registries (Source: Wikipedia)

Activity 3

Now that you have a brief idea of the prominent organisations involved in Internet governance, it is time to know more about them.

1. Find out which are the five Regional Internet Registries.
2. Visit the website of ICANN and look for the services provided by them related to domain names.

18.5 LANDMARK DECISIONS IN INTERNET GOVERNANCE

18.5.1 Net Neutrality Regulations

The guiding principle for net neutrality is that all the traffic on the Internet should be treated equally, without any discrimination or preferential treatment by Internet service providers (ISPs). Several countries have implemented net neutrality regulations to preserve an open and level playing field on the Internet. There have been landmark decisions and regulations for net neutrality to prevent discrimination and ensure equal access. They have influenced how ISPs manage and deliver internet services around the globe.

18.5.2 General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR)

The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) was implemented by the European Union (EU). Put simply, and it is a comprehensive framework for data protection and privacy. It sets strict guidelines for collecting, storing, and processing personal data. The GDPR has had a significant impact on internet governance policies globally. It influences data protection practices, user consent mechanisms, and privacy regulations.

18.5.3 Safe Harbor and Privacy Shield Agreements

The Safe Harbor and Privacy Shield agreements were arrangements between the European Union and the United States. It is intended to facilitate the transfer of personal data between the two regions and ensure adequate data protection standards simultaneously. These agreements faced legal challenges, eventually leading to discussions on cross-border data flows, privacy frameworks, and compliance with data protection laws.

18.5.4 Domain Name Dispute Resolution Policies

To ensure fair and efficient resolution of the conflicts related to the domain names, Domain Name Dispute Resolution Policies, such as the Uniform Domain-Name Dispute-Resolution Policy (UDRP), exist. These policies have played a pivotal role in addressing the conflicts related to trademark infringement, cybersquatting, and disputes related to domain name ownership.

18.5.5 Copyright and Intellectual Property Rights

Copyright and Intellectual Property Rights have been among the critical concerns of Internet governance. Notable decisions, such as the Digital

Millennium Copyright Act (DMCA) in the United States and the Copyright Directive in the European Union, have shaped policies and regulations related to copyright infringement on the Internet, digital content distribution, and the responsibilities of Internet intermediaries.

18.5.6 Cybersecurity and Anti-Spam Measures

- Considering the rise in cases of cyberattacks and spam globally, various countries have implemented laws and regulations to enhance cybersecurity and combat unsolicited commercial emails. Some noteworthy decisions and policies have been guiding the development of:
- cybersecurity frameworks
- incident response mechanisms, and
- measures to protect and increase awareness of individuals and organisations from online threats.

Activity 4

1. Look for five news items related to net neutrality in your country. What do they say?
2. Godaddy.com was in the news for the domain name dispute. Try to find out what happened and what the dispute was about.
3. Read about the landmark judgment in the case of Sameer Wadekar & Anr. Vs Netflix Entertainment Services Pvt. Ltd

18.6 INTERNET GOVERNANCE IN INDIA

18.6.1 Overview of Internet Landscape in India

Internet connectivity and usage have increased drastically in recent years in India. With the largest population in the world and a thriving digital economy, internet governance in India is a critical area of focus. This section provides an overview of the internet landscape in India, including internet penetration, digital initiatives, and the regulatory framework.

18.6.2 Legal Framework for Internet Governance

The Information Technology Act of 2000 and its subsequent amendments provide the legal framework for Internet governance in India. This section explores the key provisions and regulations related to cybersecurity, data protection, intermediary liability, and other aspects of Internet governance in the Indian context.

18.6.3 Digital India Initiative

The Indian government launched the Digital India Initiative to transform the country into a digitally empowered society and a knowledge economy. This section highlights the key components of the Digital India program, including

- efforts to enhance internet connectivity,
- promote e-governance,

- foster digital literacy, and
- leverage technology for social and economic development.

18.6.4 Role of the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI)

The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) has a crucial role in shaping internet governance policies in the country. As a regulatory body for the telecommunications sector, TRAI influences issues related to:

- net neutrality,
- data privacy,
- quality of service, and
- consumer protection.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What are the key events that contributed to the history of Internet governance?

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2. Why is Internet governance important?

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3. Identify key organisations in Internet governance and their roles.

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18.7 INTERNET GOVERNANCE: CHALLENGES AND OPPORTUNITIES

There are various challenges to achieving an egalitarian internet.

The prime concern is balancing the public good and governance practices simultaneously. The significant challenges regarding

- freedom of expression with content regulation,

- ensuring data protection and privacy,
- bridging the digital divide and
- addressing cybersecurity threats.

18.8 CONFLICTS AND CHALLENGES IN INTERNET GOVERNANCE

This section explores the conflicts related to Internet governance and the ongoing efforts to address them.

18.8.1 Government Surveillance and Privacy Concerns

One of the ongoing conflicts related to Internet governance revolves around government surveillance and privacy. Balancing the need for national security with individual privacy rights poses significant challenges. Consequently, this led to debates on user privacy susceptible to breach

- surveillance practices,
- data collection by intelligence agencies and
- the implementation of encryption standards.

18.8.2 Content Regulation and Freedom of Expression

Internet governance also tussles with balancing content regulation and freedom of expression. Determining the boundaries of permissible online content while upholding the principles of free speech and avoiding censorship is a delicate balance. Governments and online platforms confront complex decisions regarding hate speech, disinformation, and harmful content, simultaneously safeguarding individuals' right to express their opinions.

18.8.3 Cybersecurity Threats and Responses

The ever-evolving landscape of cybersecurity poses significant challenges to Internet governance. The surge in cyberattacks, data breaches, and ransomware incidents necessitates robust security measures and international cooperation. To address the current challenges in ensuring a secure digital environment, the following is required:

- Developing effective cybersecurity frameworks,
- promoting best practices, and addressing vulnerabilities.

18.8.4 Digital Divide and Access to the Internet

The digital divide refers to the disparity in internet access and connectivity across geographical regions and populations. Bridging this divide and ensuring equitable access to the Internet remains a challenge in Internet governance. The vision is to ensure that all individuals can benefit from the opportunities the Internet provides. The digital divide could be addressed by focusing on:

- expand infrastructure,

- reduce costs, and
- promote digital inclusion

18.8.5 Jurisdictional Issues and Global Cooperation

Besides the challenges mentioned above, Internet governance encounters jurisdictional challenges.

The reason is the reach of the Internet that transcends national boundaries. Hence, conflicts emerge when legal frameworks and regulations differ between countries because they affect cross-border data flows, content distribution, and jurisdictional claims. Resolving jurisdictional issues and fostering global cooperation simultaneously is a challenge and crucial for a harmonised and consistent approach to Internet governance.

18.9 CIVIC MOVEMENTS AND INTERNET GOVERNANCE

The role of civic movements for fair practices in Internet governance must be addressed. They have contributed significantly to raising awareness, shaping policies, and advocating for a more open, inclusive, and user-centric approach to Internet governance. Through their activism and engagement, they strive to safeguard digital rights, protect privacy, and promote a free and accessible internet for all. Civic movements have played a role in global Internet governance debates. Following are a few notable areas that civic movements related to and hence can be categorised as below:

1. **Net Neutrality Advocacy:**

   Various civic movements and advocacy groups have emerged worldwide to promote and uphold net neutrality. These movements mobilise public support, organise protests, and engage in online activism to raise awareness about preserving an open and neutral internet.

2. **Digital Rights and Privacy Movements:**

   With the increasing digitisation of our lives, movements focused on digital rights and privacy. These movements called for protecting individuals' rights to privacy, free expression, and access to information in the digital realm. They advocate for strong data protection laws, challenge government surveillance practices, and raise awareness about privacy issues and digital freedoms.

3. **Open Source and Free Software Movements:**

   The open-source and free software movements promote the use and development of software that can be freely accessed, modified, and distributed. These movements emphasise the importance of transparency, collaboration, and user empowerment in software development. They advocate for adopting open standards, open-source licensing, and community-driven software development models, promoting innovation and accessibility in the digital space.

4. **Access to Internet Movements:**

   There is still limited access to the Internet in many parts of the world, particularly in marginalised communities and rural areas. Movements focused on access to the internet advocate for universal connectivity and work towards bridging the digital divide. These movements seek to expand internet infrastructure, reduce costs, and promote initiatives that provide internet access to underserved populations, empowering them with the opportunities and benefits of digital connectivity.

5. **Digital Rights Movements in Authoritarian Regimes:**

   In countries with authoritarian regimes, civic movements have emerged to defend digital rights and fight against censorship, surveillance, and online repression. These movements often operate in challenging environments, using encryption tools, anonymous communication platforms, and other technologies to protect activists, journalists, and citizens from state surveillance and repression.

6. **Global Internet Governance Debates:**

   Advocacy for inclusive and participatory decision-making processes, calling for the involvement of civil society organisations and individual internet users in shaping internet policies. These movements often engage in advocacy, public consultations, and grassroots mobilisation to ensure that the voices of diverse stakeholders are heard in global Internet governance discussions.

Activity 4

Now you have read about the areas of advocacy related to Internet governance, try to look for any specific civic society movement in the following areas:

1. Digital Rights in an authoritarian state
2. Open source software
3. Net Neutrality
4. Digital rights and privacy

18.10 RANKING OF COUNTRIES IN INTERNET GOVERNANCE

18.10.1 Methodologies for Ranking Internet Governance

Different organisations use different methodologies to evaluate and rank countries. The desirable parameters for fair Internet governance include openness, security, privacy, and inclusivity.

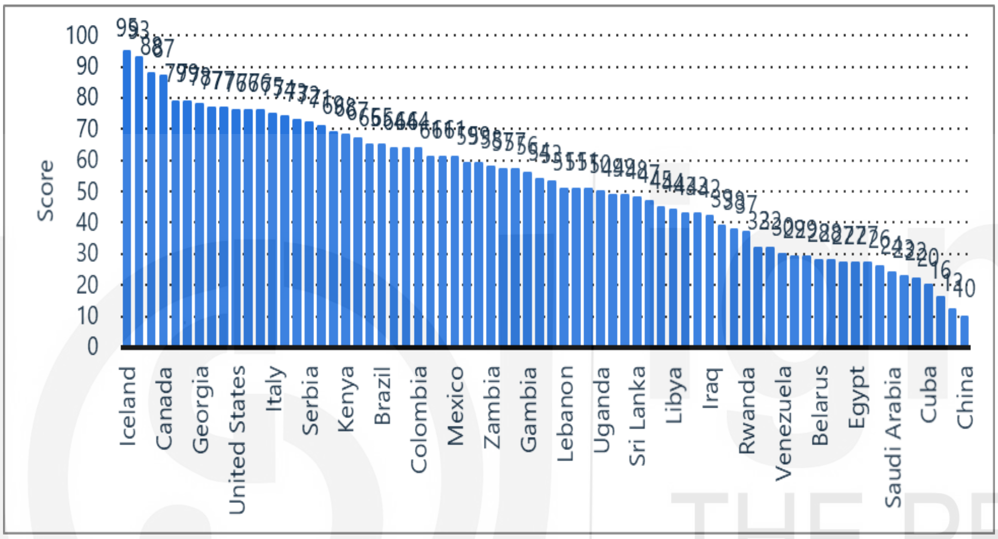
Ranking countries based on their Internet governance policies involves assessing factors like:

- legal frameworks,
- regulatory environments,
- infrastructure,

- cybersecurity measures,
- data protection regulations, and
- access to digital services.

18.10.2 Examples of Countries with Strong Internet Governance Policies

Several countries have developed strong Internet governance policies. Countries like Sweden, Germany, Estonia, and the Netherlands have been recognised for their progressive approach to digital rights, privacy protection, and promoting an open and secure Internet environment. These countries prioritise digital infrastructure, invest in cybersecurity measures, and emphasise individual privacy rights.



Degree of Internet freedom in selected countries according to the Freedom House Index in 2022 (index points) **Source(s):** Freedom House; ID 272533

18.10.3 Challenges in Assessing and Comparing Internet Governance

Assessing and comparing Internet governance across countries is challenging due to the dynamic and diverse nature of the digital landscape, along with different kinds of regulatory approaches. Cultural, social, and political contexts significantly influence Internet governance policies, which makes direct comparisons complex. Also, the constantly evolving technology requires regular updates to evaluate the methodologies used to assess Internet government practices.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What are some landmark decisions in Internet governance?

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2. How is Internet governance handled in India?

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3. What are the main challenges and opportunities in Internet governance?

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18.11 LET US SUM UP

The history of Internet governance has witnessed the evolution of organisations, policies, and regulations to address the challenges and opportunities presented by the digital realm. The importance of Internet governance lies in ensuring stability, security, openness, and protection of user rights.

Landmark decisions have shaped policies on net neutrality, data protection, copyright, and cybersecurity globally. In the Indian context, internet governance is influenced by the legal framework, initiatives like Digital India, and the role of TRAI.

However, challenges persist in government surveillance, content regulation, cybersecurity threats, and the digital divide. Resolving conflicts related to Internet governance requires balancing competing interests and fostering global cooperation.

Several countries have shown strength in digital rights, privacy protection, and infrastructure development. As technology advances and the Internet becomes an integral part of our lives, effective and inclusive internet governance becomes increasingly crucial. By addressing conflicts, embracing global cooperation, and adapting to emerging challenges, the global community can work towards a robust and equitable internet governance framework that fosters innovation, protects user rights, and ensures a secure digital future for all.

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18.13 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. The emergence of the Internet, the formation of ICANN, the role of the United States, globalisation and internationalisation, the World Summit on the Information Society, the Montevideo Statement and the IANA transition.

2. Internet governance ensures a stable and secure internet, fosters an open and innovative global platform, protects user rights and privacy, promotes global collaboration, and addresses key challenges for a harmonious online ecosystem.

3. Internet Governance Forum (IGF) facilitates discussions, ICANN manages domain names, IETF develops internet standards, W3C ensures web compatibility, and RIRs allocate IP address space.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Net neutrality regulations, GDPR for data protection, Safe Harbor and Privacy Shield agreements for data transfer, domain name dispute resolution policies, copyright and intellectual property rights, and cybersecurity and anti-spam measures.

2. India has a legal framework for internet governance, the Digital India initiative promotes digital adoption, and the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) plays a key role in regulating the telecom sector.

3. Challenges include government surveillance and privacy concerns, content regulation and freedom of expression, cybersecurity threats, the digital divide, and jurisdictional issues. Opportunities lie in promoting civic movements, global cooperation, and ranking countries based on Internet governance policies.